



CALL FOR CHANGE

Pargat Singh appointed Punjab Congress chief

NEWS » PAGE 3

VANDE MATARAM ROW

SC plea seeks two-stanza version as National Song

NEWS » PAGE 3



MANIPUR VIOLENCE

Centre yet to renew Kuki-Zo SoO pact

NEWS » PAGE 3



A NEW TEMPLATE

India's Model BIT a decade later

A clearer, more workable framework for future treaty negotiations

EDITORIAL » PAGE 6

ENVIRONMENTAL ECONOMICS

'Pay the Global South for climate damage'

NEWS » PAGE 5



Youth, leaders detained amid protests demanding CEC's exit

Opposition parties, activists, and student groups hold protests across States seeking Gyanesh Kumar's resignation; hundreds detained in Delhi; Rahul condemns police action against demonstrators, saying, 'a lathi can stop a crowd, but not a question'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Opposition parties, civil society activists, youth and student organisations held protests across the country on Friday demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

In Mumbai, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led protests at Shivaji Park received support from actors and artists. In Delhi, police detained over 500 people, including former Chief Minister Atishi.

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, condemned the police action against the protesters and said hundreds are in custody. "Their only crime is that they dared to question vote theft," he said.

Thousands joined the protests on Gandhi Jayanti, demanding Mr. Kumar's resignation. "Bapu taught



Roll call: Protest against CEC Gyanesh Kumar near Jantar Mantar, in New Delhi, on Friday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

us exactly this – speak the truth, fight peacefully. And that's what scares this government the most. A lathi can stop a crowd, but not a question. Gyanesh Kumar will go. And the system that put him there will go too," Mr. Gandhi said.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke announced that if Mr. Kumar doesn't resign, "cockroaches from across India" will protest at Jantar Mantar on October 10. All India Students' Association

National president Neha Bora has called for a fresh protest at 1 p.m. on Saturday, saying, "Jantar Mantar 2.0 is not done! It has just begun."

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said members of the Opposition parties are ready to go to jail to save democracy. The Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) national president and CPI(M) MP A.A. Rahim, who was detained

at Jantar Mantar, said the authorities denied permission for peaceful protests even at the designated protest site. "They have blocked Jantar Mantar, closed down the Metro stations and shut down the Internet... Senior leaders like Brinda Karat and M.A. Baby were detained," Mr. Rahim said.

New Delhi turned into a fortress owing to heavy police deployment and barricading at Jantar Mantar, restricting the entry of people trying to protest. The Students' Federation of India and DYFI had issued a call for the protest to begin from Mandi House. The National Students' Union of India began its march from Raisina Road and members of the Indian Youth Congress joined them.

Prohibitory orders were enforced under Section 163 BNSS in Parliament Street sub-division where the protest site is located,

restricting any public meeting. Hundreds of Delhi Police, CAPF and RAF personnel blocked the two entry points. The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation announced that entry and exit were closed at 12 stations, including those in the immediate vicinity of the protest site. Internet services were shut down.

Across India

In Keralam, district units of the CPI (M) organised rallies demanding the resignation of Mr. Kumar.

In Srinagar, scores of Congress leaders and workers assembled at the party headquarters on M. A. Road. They tried to march towards the main road, but were stopped by police. In Jaipur, the AAP held a protest at Shaheed Smarak.

EDITORIAL
» PAGE 6
RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGES 4 & 7

Trade deal with India is not 'imminent', says U.S. official

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

While negotiations on an India-United States trade deal are nearing the end, the deal itself is not "imminent", U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer indicated on Friday.

His comments followed a "constructive conversation" with Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal in the U.S. on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministerial conference. "We had a very constructive conversation, Minister Goyal and myself," Mr. Greer said at a press conference. "Our staff is meeting right now... We are continually trying to finish the trade deal with India." "I would characterise it, as we say in the U.S., we're in the short strokes," he added. "So I think we're toward the end of it. At the same time, I don't think there's something imminent."

Mr. Greer said that the two sides had identified the "universe of items" that are sticking points for both sides and are "working diligently" to address them. He added that U.S.



I would characterise it as... we're in the short strokes... So I think we're toward the end of it. At the same time, I don't think there's something imminent.

JAMIESON GREER
U.S. Trade Representative

President Donald Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi had a "constructive call" on Wednesday, and said there may be another call between them "very soon" to assess progress on the deal.

A delayed deal

The India-U.S. trade deal has been heavily delayed ever since it was announced by Mr. Modi and Mr. Trump in February 2025 due to various tariff actions taken by the U.S.

The larger Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) was supposed to have been concluded by "Fall 2025" (October-November 2025). Talks on a "mini deal" addressing only tariffs also failed to fructify. In February, the two leaders once again issued a joint state-

ment committing to finalising an interim agreement on trade, and continuing negotiating the BTA.

The interim agreement was to have been finalised by March-April 2026. Neither the interim deal nor the BTA has so far been finalised.

Mr. Goyal has been vocal in saying India will not sign a deal until it is made clear it will receive a comparative advantage over its competitors, as was agreed to in February 2026.

The U.S., on the other hand, has already levied an additional tariff of 10% on India for not doing enough to prevent the import of goods made using forced labour..

GOYAL AT G20 MEET
» PAGE 11

INSIDE

28 strategic sites get standardised names in Ladakh

NEW DELHI

The Government of India, in consultation with the Union Territory administration of Ladakh, has identified 28 places and geographical features in the region by standardised names on the official Survey of India (Sol) map. » PAGE 5

Russian strikes snarl traffic on bridges in Kyiv

KYIV

Russian aerial attacks forced the partial closure on Friday of three bridges across the Dnipro river in Kyiv, the Ukrainian capital's Mayor said. Meanwhile, Ukraine's top diplomat said officials have received proposals for a truce with Russia from U.S., India, Türkiye, and Egypt. » PAGE 12



Nine arrested for violence at Lovely varsity campus

CHANDIGARH

Nine persons including seven students have been apprehended over violence on Lovely Professional varsity (LPU) campus, police said on Friday. LPU students had held a protest on Sunday over the rape of a student on the university premises » PAGE 2

Glittering display



Reaping it rich: The Indian women's hockey team regained the gold medal after 44 years and sealed a berth for the Los Angeles Olympics. India also won three gold in boxing and one each in archery and wrestling at the Asian Games on Friday. R.V. MOORTHY (REPORT ON PAGE 14)

Reserve regains its stripes with release of tigress

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

A three-year-old tigress, T138, was released into the Buxa Tiger Reserve in West Bengal on Friday, marking the beginning of a phased programme to reintroduce tigers and establish a viable, self-sustaining population in the reserve.

The tigress was translocated from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve and released in the presence of Union Environment Minister Bhopender Yadav and West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari.

Mr. Adhikari said three more tigers would be released in Buxa in the next two months, and the initia-

tive would not only help in conservation of wildlife but also in boosting tourism in the region.

Buxa was declared a Tiger Reserve in 1983. "Over the decades, however, habitat degradation and fragmentation, changes in land use and decline in prey availability have affected the ecological conditions required to sustain a resident tiger population," a press statement by the PIB said.

Sustained effort

According to the statement, the recovery of Buxa has been a sustained, science-based effort and the Tiger Augmentation and Recovery Project, in-



New home: The tigress was brought from Valmiki Tiger Reserve, marking the beginning of a phased programme. X/BYADAVBJP

itiated by the Government of West Bengal with support from the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) and the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), has been implemented collaboratively since 2018.

Senior forest officials

said that T138 would be subject to intensive post-release monitoring using a combination of telemetry, camera trapping and field-based monitoring to assess her movement, adaptation, health and behaviour. "The programme is not

Seven killed in highway accident in Maharashtra

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

At least seven people were killed and 18 injured in an accident involving a truck and a passenger vehicle on the Samruddhi Expressway near the Dhamangaon railway station in Amravati district on Friday morning.

A senior police official said the victims were travelling from Buldhana to Wardha. Two people are reported to be in critical condition. "As per preliminary information, the truck rammed into the Bolero from behind. Five people died on the spot," a police official said. A probe is under way.

Used every bit of my energy to save lives, Captain Smit tells PM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to Flydubai pilot Captain Smit Machchhar over a video call on Friday and lauded him for foiling an attempt to crash an Israel-bound flight. Mr. Modi called the pilot a hero who proved to the world that Indians "are willing to risk their lives to save others".

"Today is Gandhi Jayanti, you have shown the world what the true meaning of 'ahimsa' (non-violence) is," Prime Minister Modi told Captain Machchhar. The pilot called Mr. Modi his "biggest idol".

Captain Machchhar is currently hospitalised in the UAE, recovering from wounds he received when his co-pilot attacked him in an alleged bid to seize control of the aircraft that was going to Tel Aviv. A wounded Captain Machchhar opened the cockpit door, following which passengers overpowered the co-pilot.

Speaking about his ordeal with Mr. Modi, Captain Machchhar said that during the scuffle with his co-pilot, his 17 years of flying made him realise the grim fate awaiting the passengers if he failed to act.

"I was lying on the floor (of the cockpit) injured. I was still getting hit, but realised that the plane was losing altitude. I told myself to give it one last try and open the door, because although I was thinking of saving myself, I could not bear to think of



what would happen to others if I didn't act. With whatever energy was left in me, I managed to act and open the door," he said, adding that passengers thereafter saved the day.

Captain Machchhar added that he always recites the Hanuman Chalisa whenever he is in difficulty, as he did that day.

Lauding the pilot's bravery, presence of mind, and composure, Mr. Modi said Captain Machchhar took the decision in a fraction of a second and saved the lives of so many people.

Enhanced honour

"After this incident, the country can proudly say that Indians are not those who take lives, but those who are willing to risk their lives to save others," Prime Minister Modi said.

"At that time, you received so many injuries and were engaged in a fight of life and death. But you ignored your own safety and were concerned about the safety of the passengers. You have enhanced the honour of 140 crore Indians. I feel proud from the bottom of my heart," Prime Minister Modi said.

INBRIEF



Sharad Pawar begins tour of drought-hit Maharashtra areas

Nationalist Congress Party (SP) chief Sharad Pawar on Friday began a tour of Maharashtra's drought-affected regions, assuring farmers that he would take up their woes regarding crop losses and severe water shortages with the State government. The former Union Agriculture Minister interacted with villagers in Purandar tehsil of Pune district to assess crop damage and water scarcity. Mr. Pawar had written to the Maharashtra Chief Minister earlier this week, pointing out that although the State government had declared drought in 265 of Maharashtra's 358 talukas, several other regions were also facing severe water scarcity and crop losses. PTI

40 fall ill after consuming 'contaminated' flour in U.P.

At least 35 women and five children fell ill after consuming suspected contaminated finger millet (ragi) flour ahead of the Jitiya fast in Uttar Pradesh's Ballia district on Friday, a health official said. The incident took place in Chhata village under the Bansdih Road police station jurisdiction, where the women consumed the flour as part of preparations for the festival. Chief Medical Superintendent Dr. S.K. Yadav said the affected women were admitted to the district hospital, with around 20 currently undergoing treatment there. "Our team is active and there is no need to worry," he told reporters. PTI

CM Vijay launches expanded no-fare bus travel for women; to cover 84 lakh beneficiaries

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay launched the 'Vettri Payanam' scheme on Friday, expanding the no-fare bus travel for women and transgender persons, at the Koyambedu bus terminus in Chennai. Coinciding with Gandhi Jayanti, Mr. Vijay kickstarted the scheme by issuing free tickets to women passengers.

The scheme will reach 84.32 lakh beneficiaries every day. It is an expansion of the five-year-old 'Magalir Vidiyal Payanam' scheme. Under the expanded scheme, women can make no-fare travel in the ordinary, express, limited stop service (LSS), and deluxe buses in cities and towns, ordinary buses in the mofussil areas, and ordinary buses in the ghat sections



T.N. Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay issuing tickets to passengers while launching 'Vettri Payanam' scheme. X/CMOTAMILNADU

beyond 40 km.

S. Malar, a resident of Chennai who was in one of the buses at Koyambedu, said, "It was pretty surreal and exciting to see the Chief Minister issue tickets to passengers." K. Abhirami, a resident of Tiruvallur, was glad the scheme was being expanded. "I had the opportunity to even take a photograph with him [Mr.

Vijay]," she said. A total of 12,695 buses under the seven State Transport Corporations have been brought under 'Vettri Payanam' and 1,68,500 trips (singles) will be operated. The scheme will not be implemented in Chengalpattu and Tiruppur districts as the model code has been in place there for the Assembly byelection.

Nagaon LS bypoll: dried fish follows biryani in campaign

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Sun- or smoke-dried fish is a delicacy in Assam. It can also be divisive at times, used for body-shaming or as a classist or racist slur against certain food cultures.

In the electoral battle for the Nagaon Lok Sabha seat, dried fish has followed biryani and biscuits to target candidates and key campaigners.

The by-election to the Muslim-dominated constituency is scheduled for October 6. Pradyut Bordoloi won the seat for the second successive term in 2024, but quit Congress to contest and win the Dispur Assembly constituency as a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) candidate in April 2026, necessitating the bypoll.



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma and Congress leader Rakibul Hussain are targeting each other through the plate. FILE PHOTO

During one of his campaigns, All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF) chief Mohammed Badruddin Ajmal referred to Congress MP Rakibul Hussain as a "madman". He also said the MP was "born eating dried fish, not biryani", a veiled reference that he is more Bengali than Assamese.

Although dried fish is popular among some indigenous communities, it is



associated more with Bengalis – Hindus and Muslims – in Assam. Bengali speakers are a sizeable population in Nagaon. A former State Minister, Mr. Hussain is a Nagaon native and a Congress key campaigner. He ended Mr. Ajmal's winning streak in western Assam's Dhubri Lok Sabha seat by more than 10 lakh votes.

The food narrative entered the Nagaon bypoll

campaign on September 28 when Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma recalled his association with Mr. Hussain during his Congress days. During one of his campaigns, the Chief Minister also commented on the latter's food habits. Mr. Hussain countered by saying God made him wealthy enough to eat biryani, while referring to Mr. Sarma's alleged weakness for biscuits.

"What can I do if he (the Chief Minister) was born to eat biscuits in the morning and at night? He got to see pulao and chicken after joining Congress," Mr. Hussain said.

The Chief Minister reacted by comparing the Congress MP to Bakasura, a mythological crane-demon with an insatiable appetite. He also said the MP consumes pulao and meat

three times before 9 a.m. "Does an infant drink its mother's milk or eat biryani after birth? Those in the former category are humans, and those in the latter are beasts," Mr. Sarma said while campaigning in the Muslim-majority Juria area.

Former Cong. bastion The Nagaon Lok Sabha constituency was a Congress bastion before Rajen Gohain won it for the BJP four times from 1999 to 2014. Congress wrested it in 2019 and 2024. The BJP has fielded former bureaucrat Devassish Sharma in the constituency. His prime rivals are former MLA Sibamoni Bora of Congress and Mr Ajmal of the AIUDF.

The constituency has 12 other contestants, including nine independents.

SP to field third candidate for Rajya Sabha, setting up stage for fight on all seats

Will take route BJP took in 2024 RS poll, says Oppn. party MP referring to ruling party's move to field extra candidate, force contest; SP backs dynasties, capitalists but seeks PDA votes: Mayawati

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW

Hinting at a possible patch-up with those who had left the party, Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Friday said the Rajya Sabha election is the "time to come together" and to "stand united with others on matters of principle".

His remarks assume significance in the context of comments made by SP Lok Sabha member Virendra Singh hours earlier – that the party will field a third candidate in the Rajya Sabha poll, setting the stage for a contest for all 10 seats that will go to the polls on October 16.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA), which has 288 MLAs in the 403-strong Assembly, is poised to secure seven seats. The SP, which has 101 MLAs and is expecting support from the Congress which has two legislators, can secure two.



Rajya Sabha election is the 'time to come together', SP president Akhilesh Yadav said at an event in Lucknow on Friday. FILE PHOTO

A tight contest is expected for the 10th seat, as the BJP is expected to have a surplus of 31 or 32 votes and the SP about 29 votes. The SP has so far nominated two candidates – senior leader Ram Gopal Yadav and industrialist Dhanraj Nathwani.

Rajya Sabha elections are based on proportional representation and single transferable vote, which ensures that the surplus votes of winners are transferred to remaining candidates according to their second preferences.

Thus, if more than 10

candidates enter the fray, the outcome will boil down to technicalities and astute planning, party leaders on both sides said.

'BJP MLAs to jump ship' Earlier in the day, Mr. Singh, the party's Lok Sabha member from Chandauli, claimed several ruling party MLAs want to contest the 2027 U.P. Assembly election on SP tickets and are in touch with his party.

On the Rajya Sabha poll, he said, "We will get all three of our candidates elected through the same route that the BJP had ta-

ken last time." He was referring to the 2024 Rajya Sabha poll, in which the BJP had fielded an eighth candidate despite having the numbers to get seven elected unopposed, forcing a contest that it eventually won amid claims of cross-voting.

'Double standard' Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief Mayawati accused the SP of practising "dynastic politics and favouring wealthy industrialists" while seeking support from the 'PDA', which is Mr. Yadav's coinage for 'Pichhde' (backward classes), Dalits and 'Alpsankhyak' (minorities).

"Public opinion suggests that the SP's third candidate will likely be a face-saving measure and a losing candidate," she said, adding that while Mr. Yadav's party seeks votes from the PDA, it "mostly elects its own family members and big capitalists as MPs and MLAs".

(With inputs from Mayank Kumar)



BJD chief Naveen Patnaik at launch of the party's 'Jan Sampark Padayatra' in Bhubaneswar on Friday. SPECIAL ARRAGMENT

Majhi govt. epitome of mismanagement, inefficiency: Naveen

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Former Odisha Chief Minister and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) chief Naveen Patnaik on Friday lashed out at Mohan Charan Majhi-led BJP government, saying it was the epitome of mismanagement and inefficiency. "This government couldn't even properly manage a single Rath Yatra. Mismanagement in flood relief, mismanagement in paddy procurement, mismanagement in recruitment examinations, mismanagement in financial management. This government has failed in every task. People are saying that perhaps the Odisha BJP government has acquired special expertise in mismanagement," he said.

The BJD on Friday launched 'Jan Sampark Pa-

dayatra', its annual month-long public outreach programme on occasion of the birth anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi. Addressing the launch of public outreach programme, Mr. Patnaik said Odisha is currently passing through a difficult period.

'No responsibility' "The Central government has taken away the rights of Odisha's residents over mines, and the Odisha government is silent, 20 BJP MPs are silent. But they are ready to fight for mine owners. It is good not to talk about textbooks for children. Thousands of mistakes. But this government is reluctant to take responsibility," Mr. Patnaik said. The BJD chief said no work is getting done, yet the debt burden is increasing.

Seven students among 9 held for violence on Lovely varsity campus

Press Trust of India
CHANDIGARH

Nine persons including seven students have been apprehended in connection with the violence on the Lovely Professional University (LPU) campus, police said on Friday.

DIG Jalandhar Range Naveen Singla told reporters on Friday that two FIRs were registered in connection with the incidents of arson, loot, rioting, infrastructure damage, police vehicles being torched, unprovoked attack on police force and blockade of the national highway. "In both these FIRs based on CCTV footage, technical analysis, media posts, social media posts and other corroborative evidence, we have carried out nine arrests so far," the DIG said.

In another incident in which students of Chitkara University in Patiala district

had held a protest a week ago and also damaged a police vehicle over unverified claims that two female students were found dead on the campus, Patiala police on Friday said they have arrested two persons for spreading rumours on social media and other platforms leading to the incident.

In the incident involving LPU University in Phagwara, Mr. Singla said four were apprehended from Phagwara, two were rounded up from Jammu and Kashmir while two were apprehended from Mumbai.

Massive protest

LPU students had held a massive protest on Sunday and also blocked a stretch of the New Delhi-Amritsar Highway outside their campus over claims that an outsider had raped a female student on the university premises.

Sena leader's murder: two key suspects arrested

Press Trust of India
THANE

The police on Friday arrested two key suspects, including the shooter, allegedly involved in gunning down of Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Pradeep Purnekar in Maharashtra's Thane city, the police said.

Acting on technical surveillance, the police nabbed shooter Nikhil Yadav and Nitesh Pawar near Pen in Raigad district in an early morning operation, securing critical leads about the Ghodbunder Road shooting, an officer said.

The fatal shooting on Tuesday night triggered tensions as hundreds of Sena (UBT) workers, alongside family members and leaders Aaditya Thackeray and Sanjay Raut, gathered outside Kapurbawdi police station, carrying Purnekar's mortal remains post-autopsy on Wednesday.

Mayawati's nephew Akash seeks another chance after expulsion

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW

A month after being expelled from the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), Akash Anand on Friday dismissed rumours that he would join another outfit and appealed to his aunt Mayawati for "an opportunity" to serve the party again.

In a post on X in Hindi, Mr. Anand referred to Ms. Mayawati as 'buaa maa' and described her as his political guru and inspiration.

This was Mr. Anand's first public reaction after BSP supremo removed him as the party's national coordinator and then removed him from the party on September 10.

His remarks came after several senior leaders indi-



Akash Anand

cated that Mr. Anand could join their parties if he wanted to.

Many offers

Nishad Party chief and Uttar Pradesh Fisheries Minister Sanjay Nishad publicly offered Mr. Anand a place in his party. Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav also indicated that the party's doors were open to him.

Union Minister and RPI chief Ramdas Athawale also

invited Mr. Anand to join his outfit. "Whatever I have learned in politics, I learned from you. Whatever I have done, I did under your guidance. Therefore, today I wish to place my words directly before you and before the entire Bahujan society. For the past few days, various kinds of news and rumours about me have been circulating in the media and social media. I want to clarify: I am not going to any other political party. The BSP is not just a party for me; it is my family," he said.

He added that he supports Ms. Mayawati's decision to expel his father-in-law, Ashok Siddharth, and sought an apology, explaining that his past silence was misunderstood.

Another pre-printed Form 7 surfaces; fuels fears of conspiracy

Swathi Vadlamudi
HYDERABAD

Apprehensions about a larger conspiracy behind the applications for bulk deletion of voters as part of the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls found validation in another pre-printed Form 7 surfacing in the Bahadurpura constituency in Hyderabad, Telangana, on Friday.

The form, sourced from the Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC), appeared ready to be filed, with the voter's name and address printed on it rather than handwritten. However, the applicant's name is missing on the form, which confirms that it was not submitted.

Not first time

The first instance of bulk Form 7s in Hyderabad surfaced on October 1, 2026, in the Musheerabad constituency. Pre-printed applications were alleged to have been filed by a Booth Level Agent (BLA) of the BJP seeking deletion of a total of 31 electors, including a Congress party's BLA and his family members.

The issue came to light reportedly when the BLA approached the family for enquiry, sources said.

The first instance of bulk Form 7s in Hyderabad surfaced on October 1 in Musheerabad

Receiving information from ground level workers, the TPCC Election Cell has started investigation in all constituencies. "We have learnt that the forms were distributed by the constituency in-charges to the division presidents who in turn distributed them to the BLAs, for filing objections," alleged sources from the Cell.

As per the original plan, the forms were to be submitted only after October 1, to overwhelm the election authorities who are already dealing with lakhs of pending hearings from the Notice Phase.

The period for filing claims and objections ends on October 7. In Musheerabad applications, the signature of the BLO was absent, making it clear that the claims were not uploaded on the Election Commission's app.

District Election Officer and GHMC Commissioner R.V. Karnan told *The Hindu* that due diligence will be observed while scrutinising Form 7 applications.

Centre yet to extend SoO pact with Kuki-Zo groups

Suspension of Operations pact to be kept in abeyance till Kuki-Zo groups surrender all weapons, say officials; Meitei, Naga groups have sought its abrogation; Shah set to visit Manipur next week

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Amid continuing violence between the Naga and Kuki groups in Manipur, the Union Home Ministry is yet to extend the Suspension of Operations (SoO) pact with the Kuki-Zo insurgent groups, a month after the one-year agreement expired.

On September 4, 2025, the Home Ministry, the Manipur government, and the Kuki-Zo groups had signed the SoO pact on "re-negotiated terms and conditions or ground rules," after the Manipur government in February 2024 refused to extend the agreement, in force since 2008, in the wake of the violence that erupted between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo people on May 3, 2023.

Pact in abeyance

Government sources told *The Hindu* that the pact is in abeyance till all weapons are surrendered by the Kuki-Zo groups. The presence of a large number of weapons with civilians is one of the prime drivers of violence and killings in the



Weapons seizure: Arms and ammunition recovered during a security forces operation in Imphal in June 2025. ANI

northeastern State, a government official said. Meitei and Naga civil society groups, including Deputy Chief Minister Losli Dikho, have demanded the abrogation of the SoO pact.

Due to Naga-Kuki ethnic tensions, more than 40 people have been killed in Ukhrul, Kangpokpi, and Kamjong districts since February 7, three days after President's Rule was revoked in the State.

A member of the Kuki-Zo SoO group said the one-year agreement expired on September 4, but they were yet to hear anything from the Ministry or Ajit Lal, Ministry's Adviser, Northeast, and the interlocutor for peace talks.

"The last meeting the SoO groups had with the interlocutor was on April 30. He had said that he will meet us every quarter. There has been so much violence in the State since February and he has not visited the affected areas even once," the SoO member said.

The member claimed that security forces conduct regular inspections of SoO camps and all weapons are accounted for. "Not extending the SoO pact does not mean it has been abrogated," the SoO member said.

During Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan's review of the security situation in the State on September 30, a senior go-

vernment official said that it was decided to send 30 more companies of the CRPF (around 3,000 personnel) and two battalions of CoBRA (around 2,000 personnel) for deployment in the State.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah is expected to visit Senapati, a Naga-dominated district in Manipur, on October 7. This will be his second visit to the State since the 2023 violence. He had visited Imphal in 2024 to address a rally ahead of the Lok Sabha elections.

History of the pact

The tripartite pact was signed in 2008 by the United Peoples' Front and the Kuki National Organisation, – a coalition of 24 insurgent groups – the Home Ministry, and the Manipur government following the Kuki-Naga clashes in the 1990s that killed hundreds. The insurgent groups demanded an independent land for the Kuki-Zo people. The pact has been extended periodically since 2008. After clashes erupted in 2023, there were strong demands from the valley areas to abrogate the SoO agreement.

Kin of 49 missing people in Manipur to get ₹10 lakh each

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Manipur Cabinet has approved a one-time financial assistance of ₹10 lakh each for the kin of the 49 people missing since the ethnic conflict erupted in the State on May 3, 2023.

Manipur's Home Minister Konthoujam Govindas told the 60-member House in September that the conflicts – first between the Kuki-Zo and Meitei communities and then between the Kukis and Nagas – claimed 306 lives and displaced more than 60,000 people.

"The Cabinet approved a Home Department proposal for the one-time assistance of ₹10 lakh each for the survivors of the 49 missing persons as a special humanitarian measure," Manipur Government spokesperson and MLA Sapam Ranjan Singh told journalists on October 1, after the end of the Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Yunman Khemchand Singh. The spokesperson said the 49 people remain missing despite search efforts.

"The decision takes into account the difficulties faced by families of missing persons, particularly be-

The ethnic conflict in the State claimed 306 lives and displaced more than 60,000 people

cause existing legal and procedural requirements make it difficult for them to access compensation available to families of those officially declared dead," he said. The law says a missing person is presumed dead only after seven years. Families of such people do not possess death certificates and autopsy reports required under the applicable Central assistance scheme.

"The families of the missing people have been going through hardships similar to those faced by the kin of people killed during the conflict. This was the reason why the government considered their case for the one-time assistance," the spokesperson said.

Among other decisions, the Cabinet also approved an increase in ex-gratia assistance for Army and Central Armed Police Forces personnel killed or injured due to extremist violence while operating in Manipur.

Plea in Supreme Court dubs six-stanza *Vande Mataram* as a 'divisive religious war song'

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A petition in the Supreme Court has termed the six-stanza *Vande Mataram* a "divisive religious war song", and said that government orders imposing a "sectarian prayer to particular goddesses of one particular religion as the National Song" violates fundamental rights of religion; attracts criminal law; and, basically, converts the Indian polity from a "secular republic" to a "theocracy".

The plea filed by B.D. Borkar, a Phule-Ambedkarite and a member of the Scheduled Caste Buddhist community of Maharashtra, represented by jurist and advocate Mohan Gopal, said that a State compulsion expressed through two successive government orders on January 28 and July 9 would lead to



A tableau by the Ministry of Culture showing the verses of *Vande Mataram* during the Republic Day Parade on January 26, 2026. ANI

the "unstated but undeniable consequence of irreversibly deepening communal division and conflict in India by outraging the religious and spiritual feelings of minority religions".

Mr. Borkar argued that the six-stanza version introduced by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee in his novel *Anandamath* would promote enmity and conflict between different com-

munities by advancing the supremacy of a dominant community. The fabric of unity would be mutilated forever, he said.

The plea said that for 79 years the Union and State governments, public institutions and other groups had peacefully played and sung the "non-*Anandamath*" two-stanza *Vande Mataram* authored by Chatterjee in the early

1870s. "This non-theistic song lauds the natural beauty of Mother Earth, describing the nation as a landscape and pays tribute to a non-deified motherland. The song was treated in this period as the National Song even though not officially declared so," the petition said.

Song versus novel

"The novel *Anandamath* was written by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee after he had composed the two-stanza standalone version of *Vande Mataram*. It was first published in 1881. *Anandamath* presents an idea of India entirely different from that found in the two-stanza standalone song... *Anandamath* is a novel in which Hindu ascetics wage a holy religious war against Muslims who are violently killed and destroyed as a people... The centrepiece of *Anan-*

damath is a six-stanza war song in which the Hindu combatants pray to Goddesses Durga, Saraswati and Lakshmi as well as the country as a goddess for victory over Muslims," the petition said.

The petition sought the court to intervene to quash the two orders, and stop any manner of compelling citizens, particularly schoolchildren, from singing or playing the six-stanza *Vande Mataram*. It said the court could direct that the two-stanza, standalone version of *Vande Mataram* alone be recognised, treated, performed and sung as the National Song.

On September 22, the top court had orally observed that a democratically-elected government cannot compel conscientious objectors to sing or play one or all the stanzas of *Vande Mataram* under the threat of penal action.

Cong. picks Aradhana Misra Mona as its U.P. chief ahead of polls

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Congress on Friday appointed Aradhana Misra Mona as president of the Uttar Pradesh Congress Committee.

Imran Masood, Lok Sabha member from Saharanpur, was appointed working president, while Devinder Nishad and Alok Prasad have been appointed senior vice-presidents of the party. Ms. Mona replaced Ajay Rai, who led the party as the State head for over three years.

Social coalition

Ms. Mona, a three-time MLA from the Rampur Khas Assembly seat under Pratapgarh district, is the daughter of party's senior leader and Deputy Leader in the Rajya Sabha Pramod Tiwari. The appointment, months before the As-



Aradhana Misra Mona

sembly polls, is seen as an attempt by the party to forge a social coalition of Brahmin-Muslim-Dalit communities as Ms. Mona and Mr. Masood hail from Brahmin and Muslim communities respectively.

Mr. Masood, the new working president, won the Saharanpur seat in 2024 by over 60,000 votes and is considered an influential Muslim leader from western U.P.



Pargat Singh

Pargat Singh appointed president of Punjab Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Putting an end to months of uncertainty around the position of the Punjab Congress chief, the All India Congress Committee (AICC) on Friday appointed Congress MLA Pargat Singh as the new president of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee (PPCC).

Mr. Singh, a former Minister and captain of the Indian men's hockey team, has been given the new responsibility, after Congress leader Amarinder Singh Raja Warring formally submitted his resignation from the post of PPCC chief to former party president Rahul Gandhi.

Mr. Singh's appointment is seen as a move to curb the ongoing power tussle in the Congress's Punjab unit. The turf war, particularly between former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi and Mr. Warring, was on public display for several months. To tackle this internal turmoil, the party's central leadership replaced Bhupesh Baghel with Sachin Pilot as the party in-charge for Punjab last month. Now, replacing Mr. Warring with Mr. Singh is also being seen as an attempt to pacify the discontented leaders ahead of the crucial 2027 Assembly polls.

Party sources said that Mr. Singh's appointment was driven largely by his clean, non-controversial image. By picking him, the party appears to have struck a balancing act, hoping he can bridge the divide between the two rival camps.

2 'intruders' shot dead by BSF along Punjab border

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Two unidentified suspected intruders were shot dead by the Border Security Force (BSF) along the India-Pakistan border in Punjab's Tarn Taran district on Friday.

A senior BSF official told *The Hindu* that the bodies were lying about 50 metres beyond the border fence till a flag meeting with Pakistan Rangers was concluded.

The official said the identities of the intruders were yet to be established. At the flag meeting, the Pakistan Rangers sought the return of the bodies. "...it has been decided to hand over the bodies after the legal formalities are completed," said the official.

UCC Bill passed by Gujarat House gets President's assent

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

The Gujarat Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill, 2026, has received the assent of President Droupadi Murmu, paving the way for its implementation, a notification published in the Gujarat government gazette has informed.

The Act will come into force on a date to be decided by the State government through a notification in the gazette.

The legislation, passed by the Assembly in March 24 after a debate lasting more than seven hours, was published in the extraordinary gazette dated October 1. The notification said the Act received the President's assent on September 17.

The Act seeks to "govern and regulate the laws relating to marriage and divorce, succession, live-in relationship and matters related thereto" and extends to the whole of Gujarat, also applying to residents of Gujarat living outside the State.

Excludes STs

The Act, however, specifically excludes members of Scheduled Tribes covered under Article 342 of the Constitution and persons or groups whose customary rights are protected under Part XXI of the Constitution.

The legislation, which provides a common framework for marriage, divorce and succession, besides regulating live-in relationships, prohibits bigamy.

Centre frames rules to standardise recruitment to various tribunal posts

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The government has come out with rules for the National Tribunals Commission which seek to standardise recruitment and eligibility for various tribunal posts; establish a formal inquiry mechanism for misconduct complaints; and to prescribe service conditions and remuneration.

Issued on September 30 and published on Thursday by the Union Law Ministry, the rules will enable the newly-created National Tribunals Commission to appoint chairpersons and members to 16 tribunals and appellate bodies.

According to the National Tribunals Commission and Qualification, Selection and Conditions of Ser-

The rules will enable the National Tribunals Commission to appoint chairpersons and members to 16 tribunals and appellate bodies

vice of Chairperson and Members of Tribunals Rules, 2026, a commission chairperson will get ₹2.5 lakh per month and commission members ₹2.25 lakh a month. A similar pay is applicable to tribunal chairpersons and members. There is a provision for specified exceptions.

The rules stipulate that the process to fill vacancies in tribunals is to be initiated at least six months before they arise. Search-cum-selection committees will assess candidates

through expert evaluation, personal interaction and, where applicable, writing exercises.

The National Tribunals Commission was set up following the passage of the Tribunals Reforms Bill by Parliament in August. The Bill was brought following a Supreme Court direction.

Ensuring independence

The key aim of the commission is to improve efficiency and ensure independence, transparency and uniformity in the qualification and appointment of chairpersons and members to various tribunals.

To be headquartered in Delhi, the proposed commission will consist of a chairperson and four members, of whom two will be judicial members and two technical mem-

bers. A retired Supreme Court judge or a retired Chief Justice of a High Court will be qualified to head the proposed panel.

The Supreme Court had recently struck down certain provisions of the Tribunals Reforms Act, 2021, on the grounds that they were contrary to the principles of separation of powers and judicial independence and not in consonance with the earlier judicial pronouncements that have clarified the standards governing the appointment, tenure and functioning of chairpersons and members of tribunals.

The court had also directed for the establishment of the National Tribunals Commission which is independent and has professional expertise.

If Gyanesh Kumar goes, Modi will have to follow suit: Dipke

Despite lack of permission, over 4,000 people turn up at Mumbai's Shivaji Park seeking CEC's resignation; personalities like Shabana Azmi and Vishal Dadlani take part in protest; this is just a trailer, full picture at Jantar Mantar, says CJP

Snehal Mutha
Yohan Varghese
MUMBAI

Thousands of protesters demonstrated outside Mumbai's Shivaji Park on Friday against alleged irregularities on electoral rolls and the Election Commission's special intensive revision (SIR), in a protest organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on the birth anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi.

Though police permission was not granted for the protest, the demonstrators numbering between 4,000 and 5,000 sat outside the historic Shivaji Park's gates in Dadar with the Tricolour in their hands, seeking the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. CJP conveners Abhijeet Dipke, Ashutosh Ranka, Saurav Das, and its head of legal affairs, Ratna Singh, addressed the protesters raising slogans such as "Gyanesh, it's done, bro".

The air was filled with slogans of Inquilab Zindabad, 'Ek Jeera, Do Ajuwain, Gyanesh karo resign', 'Gyanu kaka...rajinama dya, rajinama dya', while the beats of patriotic songs



Seeking accountability: Singer Vishal Dadlani, CJP convener Abhijeet Dipke and others at a protest demanding the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar at Shivaji Park in Mumbai on Friday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

such as *Rang De Basanti*, lent colour, sound, and defiance to an otherwise quiet afternoon.

'Freeze SIR process'

The CJP has demanded the resignation of Mr. Kumar and subsequent criminal proceedings against him. It has sought a freeze on the SIR process, restoration of the January 2025 voter list, and repeal of the 2023 law governing the appointment of Election Commissioners.

Addressing the protesters, Mr. Dipke said that if

Mr. Kumar was removed from his post, then Prime Minister Narendra Modi "will also have to go".

Mr. Ranka said: "Prime Minister Narendra Modi's shop is running because of the EC. Who the hell is Gyanesh [Kumar] to take away the Babasaheb's Constitution." He added that "this is just a trailer as the picture will be at Jantar Mantar in Delhi".

"We should not be afraid of detention. We should not be afraid of arrest. They will try to scare and threaten us, but we are

not going to be afraid," Mr. Ranka told the protesters.

Prominent figures, including actor Shabana Azmi and singer Vishal Dadlani, were present. "Since childhood we have been hearing voting is our right, but if the same right is taken away, then what will we do? We protest...", Ms. Azmi said.

Gangadhar Menon, 70, one of the protesters, said: "So far, we were talking that VVPAT (Voter Verified Paper Audit Trail) had problems, but this has gone way too deep. Now, they

are going for voters' list itself."

Comedian Rajiv Nigam, who addressed the gathering, said: "When our right to vote is taken away, all of us will have to raise our voices together."

NCP leader Anish Gawande said the SIR exercise had affected marginalised groups, claiming that "people from Assam who did not have documents because of floods" and "transgender persons without identity cards" had their names removed from the electoral rolls.

Regarding the number of protesters, a senior police official from Dadar present there said: "The inflow of people is reported to be 4,000-5,000 and police force deployed is around 800, along with riot control police units."

Senior citizen dies

A 75-year-old man who had come to witness the protest died of heart attack. He was identified as Gopalakrishna Subbairai Pillai, of Thane. Around 5 p.m., he complained of chest pain and was taken to a hospital, where he died, Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) Mahendra Pandit said.

The Hindu unveils Gandhi for Gen Z documentary

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Hindu on Friday launched its documentary *Gandhi for Gen Z* on the occasion of Gandhi Jayanti.

Editor Suresh Nambath and CEO L.V. Navaneeth released the documentary in the presence of N. Murali, Chairman, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Ltd., and N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Ltd.

The 35-minute documentary looks at the large-scale student protests earlier this year through the lens of Mahatma Gandhi's teachings about ushering in change through disciplined, non-violent protests. It proposes that the philosophies of the Mahatma may be relevant even to a generation that has not studied him beyond mentions in school textbooks.

Opening with scenes of the protests at Jantar Mantar in June and moving between archival footage of Gandhi's life and work during the freedom struggle, the film delves into how a protest triggered by a leaked examination paper expanded into an expression of young people's anxieties about today's political climate.

Besides, it looks at how the protesting students used the oldest tools in the country's political memory



N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group; N. Murali, Chairman; L.V. Navaneeth, CEO; and Suresh Nambath, Editor, *The Hindu*, at the launch of the documentary in Chennai. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

– hunger strikes and disciplined non-violent protests – tools that Gandhiji had created decades earlier.

It examines how the young protesters placed Gandhiji and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar side by side, drawing lessons from both, despite an old, established discourse that pits the two against each other.

Footage of police action against the protesters and their lack of retaliatory violence reinforced the Gandhian connection: *ahimsa*, both as moral principle and as a political strategy.

The documentary features interviews with historian and author Ramachandra Guha, former West Bengal Governor and Gandhiji's grandson Gopalakrishna Gandhi, social activist and Gandhiji's great-grandson Tushar Gandhi, Cockroach Janta Party's chief spokesperson Saurav Das, and Self-Em-

ployed Women's Association director Mirai Chatterjee.

"The documentary is very relevant and timely because it brings out, in a meaningful and real way, the relevance of India's freedom struggle, which was led by Gandhiji, particularly the method of mass protests and the reasons for not using violence," said Mr. Ram, noting that the connection between the freedom struggle and the student protests is portrayed very authentically in the documentary.

The documentary was spearheaded by Pradeep Gairola, business head – digital, The Hindu Group. It was directed by Shikha Kumari A. and edited by Naveen Kumar V., with camerawork and post-production handled by members of *The Hindu's* video team. It is available on *The Hindu's* YouTube channel.

EC directs BLOs to enrol voters left out of SIR rolls within a month

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission (EC) has directed the Chief Electoral Officers (CEO) of all States and Union Territories where the special intensive revision (SIR) has been completed or is under way to compare the pre-SIR voter lists with the current ones and enrol, within one month, those who have been left out but are eligible.

In a letter to the CEOs of all States and Union Territories, the EC has said that booth-level officers (BLO) should prepare a list of electors whose names had been left out, and make door-to-door visits to ascertain their present status and ensure their enrolment through Form 6 if the concerned person is found eligible.

"BLOs shall compare the current electoral roll with the pre-SIR electoral roll and identify such electors whose names were there in the pre-SIR roll but



who are not included in the current electoral roll and prepare a list of such electors," the letter said.

It further said that BLOs shall undertake house-to-house visits in respect of such identified electors to ascertain their present status and facilitate enrolment through Form 6, wherever the person is found to be eligible.

The EC's letter, which was issued after a video conferencing with all the CEOs, suggested that the BLOs may cover at least 20-25 electors in a week so as to complete this exercise

within a period of about one month.

"They shall also indicate the present status of each such elector in the list prepared by them. The electors for whom Form 6 has been filled up will also be indicated."

The BLOs will share this list with the BLAs of recognised political parties and the EROs, along with filled-in Form 6 application forms and their field verification reports.

Booth-level camps

Apart from this, booth-level camps shall be organised to facilitate submission of applications for enrolment. Special camps may also be organised for enrolment of people living in night shelters, labour colonies as well as for homeless and marginalised persons.

Till now, approximately 13.3 crore names have been deleted from the electoral rolls in States where the SIR process has been completed or is under way.

An analysis by *The Hindu* found that around 2.7 crore or 21% have been declared dead, and of the remaining, approximately 1.01 crore have been flagged as multiple entry cases and 9.5 crore marked in the absent/shifted/others category. This in effect means that 72% of the voters whose names have been deleted could be back in the voter lists once the SIR process is completed.

The EC has already announced a special drive to enrol new voters.

However, former Chief Election Commissioner S.Y. Quraishi has questioned the EC's move to re-enrol voters using Form 6.

He said Form 6 cannot be filled by a deleted voter. "It's only for NEW voters. All those who have been forced to fill it have committed criminal offence carrying one year prison. EC officials who forced them are abettors to crime. This press note shows EC's abetment!", he said in a post on X.

Re-enrolment drive will not include Bengal voters under adjudication

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission's (EC) special "door-to-door" drive to re-enrol any voter left behind during the SIR process through Form 6 will not be applicable to the more than 20 lakh voters in West Bengal whose cases are pending before the appellate tribunals. This could create two parallel re-enrolment routes, one through the tribunals and one through Form 6 applications to electoral registration officers (EROs). The EC has directed Form 6 applicants to be cleared within a month, while the tribunal appellants could wait several years.

A senior EC official told *The Hindu* that while booth-level Officers (BLOs) would re-check if any voters are left out among the ASDD (absent/shifted/dead/duplicate) list which was issued after the enumeration phase, those whose cases are in the tri-



People gather to submit their applications to a tribunal set up to hear appeals related to SIR in Alipore, Kolkata. FILE PHOTO

bunals "is different as it is already under adjudication".

According to an affidavit submitted by the EC in the Supreme Court, 22.21 lakh appeals are pending before the tribunals in West Bengal.

The appellate tribunals came out of Supreme Court's supervision of the SIR. Judicial officers, drawn from a list sent by the Calcutta High Court at the Supreme Court's direction, were adjudicating the roughly 60 lakh "doubtful

and pending" cases. On March 10, the apex court directed that a separate appellate body be set up so that people could challenge those officers' decisions. On March 21, the EC constituted 19 Appellate Tribunals for West Bengal.

Before this, during enumeration phase, about 31.7 lakh voters (31,68,424) were identified as "unmapped", meaning they could not be linked to the 2002 electoral roll. A further approximately 1.36 crore were flagged under

"logical discrepancy". Both groups were called for hearings after the draft roll was published on December 16 last year.

Around 60 lakh cases were still unresolved when the final roll was published on February 28 after the hearings had cleared the rest.

Unresolved appeals

The West Bengal Congress has said that since the enrolment drive was announced just before the October 6 by-elections in Nandigram and Rejinagar, where over 6,000 and 12,000 appeals, respectively, remain pending, these voters would be deprived of their vote for a second consecutive time. The party unit chief, Shubhankar Sarkar Prasenjit Bose, in a letter to the EC, asked for all 22.21 lakh appellants to the electoral roll to be restored provisionally until their appeals are finally decided, or to convert all pending tribunal appeals into Form 6 applications.

Cong. accuses EC of 'lying' about ECINet, demands accountability

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday accused the Election Commission (EC) of "lying" about the legality of its ECINet platform and violating electoral laws, with party general secretary Jairam Ramesh demanding accountability for what he described as "violations of the law and the Constitution".

Mr. Ramesh said the EC, in a September 26 press note, had announced the formation of a committee to certify that ECINet complied with the relevant Acts and Rules. He described the move as "damage con-

trol but actually damage enhancing".

"This should never have been in doubt at all in the first place if the intentions of CEC Gyanesh Kumar were honest – which they were not," he said.

ECINet was launched on January 22 with the stated objective of enhancing transparency and public trust. The EC had said at the launch that the platform had been "developed in strict accordance with the law". "All of this was a lie," Mr. Ramesh said.

He alleged that by restricting electoral registration officers' (EROs) access to the ECINet voter-roll system and overruling EROs

in Goa, West Bengal and other States, the EC had violated the Representation of the People Act, 1950 and the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

"Both these laws establish that the ERO has statutory authority over the electoral roll," he said, citing a September 24 letter from the Maharashtra Chief Electoral Officer seeking correction of the alleged irregularity.

"Starting today, the INDIA janbandhan, citizens and many civil society organisations will hit the streets across the country demanding accountability for these violations," Mr. Ramesh said.

INDIA bloc leaders take out march in Bihar; demand CEC's resignation

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Leaders of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance in Bihar on Friday said that the people's right to vote is under attack, and votes are being stolen. The leaders said this during the Save Democracy March organised in State capital, Patna, in which the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), Congress, and Left parties participated.

Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya led the march.

Addressing the gather-



CPI (ML) general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya and others stage a protest at Gandhi Maidan in Patna on Friday. ANI

ing, Mr. Bhattacharya asserted that today Gandhi's land is ruled by those who follow Godse and the law and the Constitution are

being openly flouted. He alleged that elections are being influenced in favour of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

Panel of ex-judges to inquire into SIR aftermath

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A lawyers' group issued a statement on Friday announcing the constitution of an independent panel of former Supreme Court and High Court judges to enquire into growing concerns regarding the design, implementation, and consequences of the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise undertaken by the Election Commission.

The Lawyers Association for Constitution (LAFAC) said the panel aims at coming up with a report by December 2026.

INBRIEF



IIT-B students begin hunger strike protesting Sahil's death

A group of IIT-Bombay students protesting against the death of second-year student Sahil Wakode began a hunger strike on Friday, demanding accountability from the institute's administration and the resignation of its Director. The students, who have been protesting for the past 15 days, decided to intensify their agitation after Wakode's parents, who are on a hunger strike at Azad Maidan in Mumbai, were denied permission to continue their protest on weekends. Mr. Wakode was found dead in his hostel room at the IIT on September 18. His family alleged he had faced caste-based discrimination at the institute.

Counselling is available at Tele MANAS 14416.

HC to hear PIL plea on noise pollution after student's death

The Allahabad High Court has initiated *suo motu* proceedings on noise pollution following reports of the death of a seven-year-old Class 2 student at a school in Balrampur on September 22 while a procession carrying loudspeakers and a music system was passing nearby. According to reports, the procession was part of the 10-day Ganpati Utsav. Observing that the death raises larger questions over the unchecked menace of noise pollution, a Division Bench of Justice Rajan Roy and Justice Manjive Shukla on Wednesday ordered registration of a separate *suo motu* PIL plea while hearing an existing case concerning the use of pressure horns, modified silencers, and hooters.

Constable found dead in Bijapur; kin allege 'murder'

A 40-year-old police constable allegedly ended his life by shooting himself with his service rifle in Chhattisgarh's Bijapur district, the police said on Friday, even as his family alleged that he was murdered. Constable Vijendra Thakur, of the Chhattisgarh Armed Force (CAF), shot himself on September 30 at Sendra Camp in Farsegarh police station area, the Bijapur Police said in a statement on Friday. Initial investigations concluded that it was a suicide, and an accidental death report has been registered at Farsegarh police station, and the matter is being probed, the statement added. However, Thakur's family allege that he had been murdered.

Day after arrest, 'Mohammad' Deepak gets bail in 'abuse' case

A day after he was arrested for allegedly abusing a businessman, Deepak Kumar, alias 'Mohammad' Deepak, a gym owner from Kotdwar, Uttarakhand who came into limelight earlier this year after confronting right-wing activists over harassment of a Muslim shopkeeper, got bail from a local court on Friday. He was arrested after the businessman filed a complaint alleging abuse, assault and threat. According to police, Mr. Kumar was booked under Sections 351(2) (criminal intimidation), 352 (intentional insult with intent to provoke breach of peace), 196 (promoting enmity between different groups) and 115 (voluntarily causing hurt) of the BNS.

Pay the Global South for climate damage: economist

Michael Greenstone says that such payments should be contingent on developing countries adopting carbon pricing; exact parameters of agreements would have to be negotiated, he adds

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Rich countries should pay people in developing countries for the climate damage their emissions cause, on condition that those countries put a price on carbon. That is the central proposal of a forthcoming book, *Just Economics*, by University of Chicago economist Michael Greenstone, with Nobel-Prize winning economists Abhijit Banerjee and Esther Duflo. "We're proposing Indians receive money unencumbered," Mr. Greenstone, who is Director, Energy Policy Institute, University of Chicago, said in an interview. "Spend it on whatever you want. That is based on the amount of damage the OECD countries' emissions are doing." The payment, he said, "would go directly to the people, not to the government."

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), is a grouping of mostly wealthy, industrialised countries that has contributed to most of the accumulated carbon in the at-



mosphere driving global warming. This contrasts with the "Global South", meaning low- and middle-income countries but whose emissions are fast rising. "Eighty two per cent of the emissions going forward are projected to be outside the OECD and moral appeals have failed," he reckoned, "the better angels-argument ain't working." However the transfer would be "contingent on the Global South adopting carbon pricing. It's not for free. It's a deal. You have to give something to get something."

Mr. Greenstone said it was possible to calculate the damage from carbon emissions to India. "However the exact parameters of that will have to be

negotiated. Such a deal did not require the whole world and could be struck between, say, the European Union and India, he argued.

Market-based solution

Much of Mr. Greenstone's work is around designing market-based solutions to address pollution. Most prominent is the Surat Emissions Trading Scheme for controlling particulate matter, first mooted with the Gujarat Pollution Control Board in 2010. In a randomised trial, 150 textile plants were assigned to a market and 150 stayed under conventional regulation. Compliance in the market was "99%", against about a third of industries out of compliance at any

time under the status quo. This happened because researchers could see what firms bid to buy and sell permits: "The price I want for that has got to be at least what it cost me to do it. From those bids, we were able to infer how expensive it was to achieve different levels of total emissions. Cutting emissions proved cheap, because the guys had all the equipment and just had to start operating it or maintaining it," he explained. Enforcement mattered. When firms fell short of permits, the regulator levied a fine of ten times the permit value. "Once the industry saw that the rules were going to be enforced then everything changed," he said.

While the Surat system was designed to reduce particulate matter from textile mills, the next stop is Maharashtra, where the market will cover sulphur dioxide – a gaseous pollutant – and include large power plants. He said that a "mock trading period involving an actual market, without real money, was under way to get firms used to trading permits before the real market opened.

Indore water deaths probe report was manipulated to protect BJP leaders: Cong.

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

The Congress on Friday alleged that the one-man judicial commission report on the Indore water contamination tragedy was "manipulated to protect" Bharatiya Janata Party leaders, including Mayor Pushyamitra Bhargava and Bhagirathpura councillor Kamal Baghela, by "putting pressure" on Justice Sushil Kumar Gupta (ret'd), who headed the panel.

Addressing a press conference in Indore, Leader of the Opposition in the Madhya Pradesh Assembly Umang Singhar said the water quality in India's cleanest city had fallen to the level of "small villages in Africa", and sought a first information report



Umang Singhar

against those responsible for the tragedy, that claimed more than 30 lives between December 2025 and February 2026.

Akin to Africa's villages

"This is the 21st century but even quality drinking water is not being made available. The situation in Indore, which is an economically emerging city, is today similar to that in Afri-

ca's small villages. The Indore Municipal Corporation [IMC] has an annual budget of ₹8,500 crore," he said, accusing the BJP of failing to provide clean drinking water.

Citing an IMC report, Mr. Singhar said many areas and various government hospitals in Indore were still receiving water, contaminated with bacteria such as E. coli, even after eight months since the tragedy.

Mr. Singhar accused the BJP government of failing to fix accountability, despite the probe report blaming the tragedy on institutional failure due to several long delays that go up to 859 days in replacing or repairing the damaged water pipeline in Bhagirathpura, the hot spot of the tragedy.

India standardises names of 28 places in Ladakh

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Government of India, in consultation with the Union Territory administration of Ladakh, has identified 28 places and geographical features in the region by standardised names on the official Survey of India (SoI) map.

The government said the formal identification on the map was aimed at ensuring accurate recognition and creating greater awareness among the public. The latest notification comes days after India standardised the names of places in Arunachal Pradesh amid cartographic aggression by China.

The list in Ladakh includes 11 peaks, five mountains, six land areas, two glaciers, two passes, one valley, one river, one lake and one other water body.

Rising food prices affecting kitchen budgets: Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of being insensitive to the burden of rising food prices on households, with the party's communication chief, Jairam Ramesh, describing him as the *pravachan mantri* (sermonising Minister).

Mr. Ramesh shared on X a media report which said household kitchen budgets had increased by 20% to 25% over the past three months.

"Inflation isn't just rising in statistics; its pain is being felt in the kitchens of every middle-class and poor household," he said in a post, alleging that the kitchen budget had risen by up to 25% in three months and that too during the festival season.

Citing the experience of a homemaker with a monthly income of ₹35,000, the Congress leader asked, "Does Modi realise how all these families must be managing their household budgets in this era of inflation?"

Mr. Ramesh cited increases in the prices of several food items, saying *arhar dal* had risen from ₹105 to ₹140-₹150 a kg, *moong* from ₹95 to ₹120,



Jairam Ramesh

rice from ₹42-₹45 to ₹53-₹55, and mustard oil from ₹165 to ₹190 a litre.

He also cited government data to say food inflation stood at 5.95% in August, while onion, ginger, and garlic prices had risen by 48.27%, 73.82%, and 43.6%, respectively.

"For the government, these may be just numbers, but for the public, it's a household budget unravelling every month," Mr. Ramesh said. "When will the people of the country get relief from this back-breaking inflation? The insensitivity of the *pravachan mantri* knows no bounds."

The government, however, has dismissed the Opposition's claims and pointed to the strength of the economy, including the latest GDP numbers.

Shachmirk Pass have been identified as passes.

Other features on the list include Shkorga Valley, Yangpa River, Guru Rinpoche, which has been identified as a lake, and Hot Spring, classified as a water body.

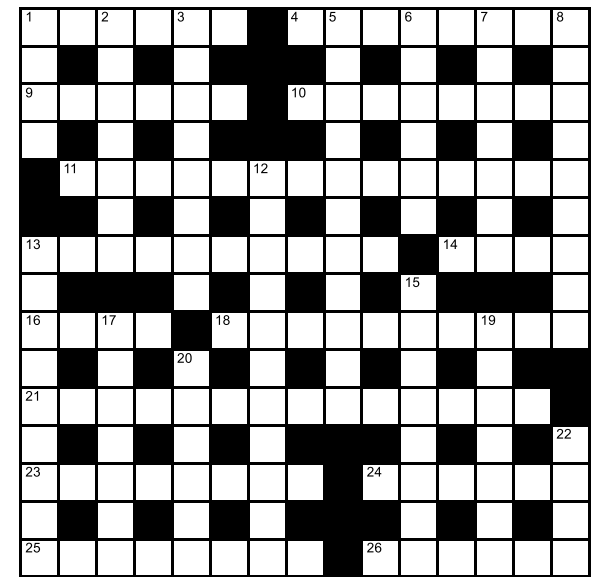
The government said the map of Ladakh, incorporating the additional places and geographical features, can be viewed on the Survey of India website.

Since April 2020, the Chinese People's Liberation Army (PLA) has amassed a large number of troops and armaments in eastern Ladakh and other areas along the 3,488-km-long LAC. The PLA moved into Indian territory and built fortified structures and defences, in an attempt to permanently alter the *status quo* on the ground.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14914 (set by Avtaar)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

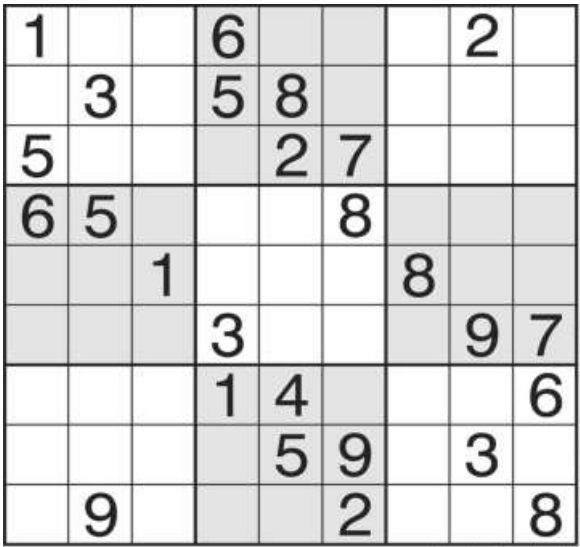
SCAN TO PLAY



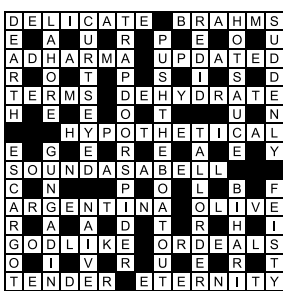
- 13 Throughout a meeting emotional quotient essentially found wanting (10)
- 14 Partners exchanged, means to send data for tweeters? (2-2)
- 16 Playful bow (4)
- 18 Part of physics involving inversion of model data (10)
- 21 Shouting *Help*, say, about introduction of arbitrary rule probing storage fee (8,6)
- 23 Director left for Illinois, developing office tower? (8)
- 24 Smelly wonky old studio releasing toxins at the entrance (6)
- 25 Doctor listened and volunteered (8)
- 26 Right through, ace is ahead (6)
- Down**
- 1 Exposed factor in rising redundancy (4)
- 2 Mom's vehicle given touch of artificial colouring in front (7)
- 3 Wife visiting America enters Michigan, say, with Republican congressman (8)
- 5 Composed a story *Ditch of Still Water*? (11)
- 6 Foot for base of prop in releasing counter (6)
- 7 One old Communist leader turned up checking doctor's paperwork? (7)
- 8 Science of drawing? (9)
- 12 Leader quitting act of voluntary humiliation following judge's sanction (11)
- 13 Short-tempered herbalist uncovered case of Icelandic nuts (9)
- 15 Head to investigate mudslinging Brit? (8)
- 17 Cheerful bird lifted face (7)
- 19 Smart married women leaving tribe? (7)
- 20 Group of stars held at the borders, say, furtively hiding ecstasy (6)
- 22 Sailor entertains special authority on a subject (4)

- Across**
- 1 That is Avtaar entering when I have left, naturally (6)
- 4 Amateur boxing tour disrupted near Cambodia's capital (8)
- 9 Abandon plant amidst pandemonium (6)
- 10 Uplifting energy provided in passing (8)
- 11 Supply from Canada losing money with onset of recession almost trebled result of international sales (7,2,5)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

Kindness conquers all

The word *vazhga* appears six times in the opening lines of Saivite preceptor Manikkavachakar's Siva Puranam. What does it signify? It refers to the six enemies within us, said Dr. Sudha Seshayyan.

Manikkavachakar says the six enemies are *kamam* (desire), *krodham* (anger), *lobham* (greed), *moham* (delusion), *madam* (ego) and *matsaryam* (jealousy). They reside within the five senses and these five should not be merely overcome but won. No one can predict when any of these will surface. Even in bhakti these traits might show and should be mastered. The example of Sundarar's experience at Devasriya mandapam in Tiruvavur is a case in point.

Sundarar, one of the four Saivite preceptors along with Manikkavachakar, had a wonderful relationship with God, due to which he ignored other *adiyars* (servants of God), overlooking the tenet that one should first pay obeisance to the servitors before praying to God at the Devasriya mandapam. Noticing this, Virumandiyar, a servitor stopped Sundarar from proceeding towards the deity. Impelled by his ego, Sundarar refused to acknowledge the servitors and stormed out. Walking agitatedly within the compound, he passionately asked Siva why He did not stop the servitor, thereby denying him a darshan. Suddenly, the preceptor heard a voice calling out to him from above; looking about he espied the deity standing precariously on the temple gopuram. Sundarar conquered his ego and made peace with the servitor. God never leaves the hearts of His devotees, no matter how many deficiencies there may be. Kindness conquers all.



Obstacle race

The Special Intensive Revision exercise is threatening universal adult franchise

On Gandhi’s birth anniversary, many Opposition parties, student groups and other citizens took to the streets in Delhi, Mumbai and elsewhere demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. Their grievance was that Mr. Kumar has presided over a Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise meant to “clean” the electoral rolls, but in practice has become an exercise in the serial disenfranchisement of lakhs of Indian citizens. The BJP-led Union and State governments reacted predictably, refusing permission for the protest and imposing prohibitory orders. In Delhi, the government shut down the Internet in the Jantar Mantar area, closed 11 Metro stations and detained over 700 protesters. In Mumbai, the police denied permission for the gathering at Shivaji Park, but the protesters turned up anyway. The reason for the anger is plain. Emboldened by a deferential Supreme Court verdict upholding the SIR’s constitutional validity, the Election Commission of India (ECI) has taken the flawed method that it first adopted in Bihar, added a new exclusion criterion called “logical discrepancies” that it first implemented in West Bengal, and extended it from State to Union Territory (UT). The enumeration process puts the onus on electors to prove their eligibility, with many deleted first and verified later. Getting back onto the rolls after being struck off the draft is onerous, while dubious mass requests for deletion are easy to file and quick to process. Nearly 13.4 crore electors have been removed from the draft rolls across 30 States and UTs – about 14% of the electorate before the revision. Each phase has deleted more than the last: 8.3% in Bihar, 12.9% across the 12 States and UTs of Phase 2, and 17% in Phase 3.

The ECI has said that deleted electors can return during the claims phase, but only as fresh applicants provided they find that they have been struck off. The ECI’s own members objected to the plainly illegal changes to procedure. Form 6 was altered without any amendment to the rules, asking applicants whether they, or their parents or grandparents, appeared on the roll of the last SIR. In West Bengal, 16.1 lakh requests were filed to remove electors whom judicial officers had already cleared. A centralised roll database in New Delhi helped make this possible. The ECI has now asked BLOs to restore deleted voters to the rolls; it is an implicit admission that the process disenfranchised many. The semi-corrective steps do not absolve the two Election Commissioners. As majority in the ECI, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi could have overruled the CEC. The exercise, as it is being carried out now, is an obstacle not only to universal adult franchise but also to electoral democracy itself.

Rescue act

Preventing ecological degradation is the way to protect wildlife

The first tiger to be reintroduced in West Bengal represents a triumph of bureaucracy, not ecology. After the National Tiger Conservation Authority found no tigers in the Buxa, Dampa, and Palamau reserves by 2018, it mooted a programme with the Bengal Forest Department and the Wildlife Institute of India that has culminated with a royal Bengal tigress caught in Bihar to be released in Buxa. She is the first of seven to be relocated over two years. Buxa is dotted with settlements and surrounded by revenue villages and tea estates. The region already hosts an elephant population routinely threatened by a railway line, with the railways also planning to restore a route to Jainti. Commercial traffic on the Bhutan-West Bengal road through Buxa is another problem. Estates are also notorious for fragmenting the landscape, including migration corridors. The area’s forests have turned into dense woodland with a closed canopy, stifling the growth of grasses and causing herbivore populations to dwindle. The density of chitals, tigers’ prey, is dismal; goats, macaques and cattle have become more common in tiger diets in place of their preferred ungulates. Since 2018, the collaboration has reintroduced chitals; artificially opened some canopies to help revive grasslands; and relocated villagers from the reserve’s core to mitigate human-wildlife conflicts. This last measure is, however, also a window into the cynical character of the reintroduction programme.

From 1973, India followed preventive conservation practices that protected source populations and their habitats, and maintained prey bases and corridors. Buxa, however, belongs to a more recent, more reactive tradition that also includes Sariska and Panna, where authorities intervened only after tiger populations crashed. A reintroduction programme showcases technical capabilities but is also more expensive and heavy-handed, and reflects Project Tiger’s problematic belief that the core habitat needs to be inviolate – one the state machinery has used to override the rights of Adivasis and forest-dwelling communities and disrupt incomes from ecotourism. The reserve is also part of an international wildlife corridor contiguous with Phibsoo in Bhutan, to the north, and Manas in Assam to the east. If these forests offer higher prey density or fewer disturbances, the tigers may disperse. Success at Buxa means introduced tigers establish territories and produce cubs, which survive and breed, with natural immigration maintaining genetic diversity. But success should also be an advance, rather than a rescue, and entails monitoring ecological deterioration such that the state does not wait for tigers to vanish to act and involving communities in and around Buxa in decisions about preventing conflicts and protecting livelihoods.

On September 23, a two-judge Bench of the Supreme Court of India, comprising Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma, delivered a split verdict on a set of petitions which assailed the validity of the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023. Remarkably, the judges were divided not on the merits of the challenge, but on whether a Bench of two was competent to decide the matter at all.

An appointment framework

The statute, which was enacted in December 2023, provides that the Chief Election Commissioner and the Election Commissioners shall be appointed on the recommendation of a selection committee comprising the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, and a Union Cabinet Minister nominated by the Prime Minister. This law replaced an interim arrangement that a Constitution Bench of five judges had put in place in *Anoop Baranwal vs Union of India* (2023). Under that arrangement, the Chief Justice of India (CJI) sat as the third member in place of a Minister.

Midway through the hearings in the matter, which began in May, the Union government changed tack and argued that the case raised a substantial question of law as to the interpretation of the Constitution. It therefore claimed that the challenge, in terms of Article 145(3), ought to be heard by a Bench of at least five judges. Curiously, this plea was made even though it found no place in the Union’s counter-affidavit.

While Justice Datta rejected the request, Justice Sharma accepted it. Ordinarily, a difference of opinion on a Bench of two is resolved by a Bench of three. But reasoning that a ruling on which of their opinions was correct would only delay matters further, both judges jointly placed the papers before the CJI asking him to consider constituting a Constitution Bench. The upshot is this: the petitioners, who came to court in early 2024, must now wait again.

As Justice Datta rightly held, Article 145(3) merely prescribes that a case involving a substantial question of constitutional interpretation ought to be decided by a Bench comprising a minimum of five judges. It does not ask whether a case is important or whether a statute under challenge is new. As far back as in 1959, in *State of Jammu and Kashmir vs Thakur Ganga Singh*, the Court explained, albeit in a different context, what a question of constitutional interpretation entails. “The question of interpretation can arise only if two or more possible constructions are sought to be



Suhrit Parthasarathy
Advocate practising in the Madras High Court

The Court needs structural reform to strengthen constitutional adjudication and consistency

placed on a provision – one party suggesting one construction and the other a different one,” the Court had held. “But where the parties agree on the true interpretation of a provision or do not raise any question in respect thereof, it is not possible to hold that the case involves any question of law as to the interpretation of the Constitution.” A Bench of three judges later applied the same reasoning to Article 145(3) itself, in *People’s Union for Civil Liberties vs Union of India* (2003).

A deeper institutional fault

What, then, did *Anoop Baranwal* settle? Justices Datta and Sharma agreed that the committee the judgment had created was a stopgap, meant to last only until Parliament enacted a law. To that extent, the Union may well be right in claiming that the CJI’s place on the committee is by no means constitutionally entrenched. But the Constitution Bench also read Article 324 to require that appointments to the Election Commission be insulated from exclusive executive control. This was a clear declaration of law, binding on every court under Article 141. As Justice Datta held, whether a committee in which the executive holds two votes out of three meets that standard is merely a question of applying this settled rule to a new statute.

Justice Sharma’s opinion adopted a different test. He held that since “there is no authoritative decision of this Court till date pronouncing upon the constitutional validity of the [2023] Act, the matter must be heard by a Constitution Bench of not less than five Judges.” But almost any challenge to a fresh statute would, in this sense, be the first of its kind. On such logic, Benches of two judges could not have decided *Shreya Singhal vs Union of India* (2015), which struck down Section 66A of the Information Technology Act or *NALSA vs Union of India* (2014), which affirmed the right of transgender persons to their self-identified gender. Each called for a searching analysis of the Constitution and its guarantees.

Ultimately, though, a disagreement of this kind points to a deeper fault in the Court’s architecture.

When the Court first sat, in January 1950, it had six judges (a sanctioned strength of eight judges). Article 145(3), with its minimum of five, assumed that the Court would, in the main, sit together to interpret the Constitution. Today the Court has a sanctioned strength of 38 judges. It functions largely in panels of two and spends most of its time on special leave petitions. A Constitution Bench is assembled only when the CJI can spare at least five judges from this daily churn. The result, as the scholar Nick Robinson has argued, is not one court but many, with each Bench speaking in its own voice.

India’s Model BIT — a decade later, amid changes



Ivoti Singh
Advocate based in Delhi and has been a legal consultant to the Department of Economic Affairs, Government of India

negotiations, while leaving sufficient room for necessary adjustments in individual agreements. It is here that the contributions of Makane Moïse Mbengue are relevant. His scholarship teaches that a developing state need not always be a rule-taker under international investment law, but can also be a rule-shaper through its treaty practice. India’s revamp of its Model BIT offers a similar opportunity.

The international context has also changed. The United Nations Trade and Development (UNCTAD) points to a shift toward investment facilitation, cooperation, sustainable development and more carefully defined investor protections, with less reliance on traditional investor-state dispute settlement (ISDS). The United Nations Commission on International Trade Law (UNCITRAL) is examining reforms to the ISDS, including a permanent tribunal and appellate mechanism, damages and compensation, and dispute prevention. India’s revised Model BIT must therefore respond to a changing investment regime, not merely revisit the 2015 Model.

What a new model must factor in

The new model must consider whether to include the Most Favoured Nation (MFN) provision. In most investment treaties entered into by India, the MFN provision is absent, reducing the possibility for an investor to claim better protection under other treaties. However, if the new model includes this provision, it should be very clear about its scope. In *Emilio Agustín Maffezini vs Kingdom of Spain*, an MFN clause was used to bypass an 18-month local-court requirement by relying on more favourable dispute-settlement provisions in another treaty. *Plama Consortium Limited vs Republic of Bulgaria* rejected the importation of such provisions in the absence of a clear treaty provision. Recent treaty drafting also provides examples of expressly excluding dispute-settlement procedures from the scope of MFN clauses. The scope of the MFN provision should therefore be defined, particularly in relation to dispute settlement.

India must draw lessons from a decade of investment treaty experience

To be fair, the joint order signed by Justices Datta and Sharma recognises as much. *Anoop Baranwal* arose out of a petition instituted in 2015, was referred to a Constitution Bench in 2018, and was decided in 2023. The reference in *State of Uttar Pradesh vs Jai Bir Singh*, to decide what counts as an “industry”, lay dormant for 15 years from 2002, and took nine more to reach the nine-judge Bench that finally decided it. The judges themselves describe such delay as a source of “institutional embarrassment.”

The need for clearer rules

Delay of this kind carries with it a corrosive consequence: it presents the Court with a *fait accompli*. Take the present challenge. By the time it is decided, Commissioners appointed under the law would have overseen multiple State elections and likely multiple general elections too. In their joint order, the judges ask the CJI to explore a permanent Constitution Bench to decide pure questions of constitutional law. The idea is far from new. The Law Commission, in its 229th report in 2009, proposed a Constitution Bench sitting in Delhi, with Benches in different regions of the country hearing ordinary appeals.

A Bench of that form would need no constitutional amendment. The CJI, as the Master of the Roster, can create one tomorrow. But therein lies another difficulty. On a court of 38 judges, the power to decide who sits on which Bench is more than an administrative power. It can, and often does, shape outcomes. We might therefore ask ourselves whether such authority ought to be concentrated in a single office. For a permanent Bench to command confidence, it must be composed through a procedure that is transparent, settled in advance, and based on bright-line rules.

There is, however, a further difficulty. India’s legal system is built on a supposed commitment to the principle of *stare decisis*, a promise to stand by things previously decided. Yet, there is little to suggest that the Court’s Benches, whatever their size, will consistently honour what earlier Benches have held. The present case shows as much. A Bench of two, albeit divided, has declined to apply a principle settled by a Bench of five, and has sent the case to a Constitution Bench simply because the statute under challenge is new.

The Court, in its original conception, was seen as a guardian of the Constitution that would also hear appeals. Over time, though, it has become a forum that sits predominantly as a court of appeal rather than as a constitutional court. This inversion demands urgent correction. Otherwise, the gravest questions facing the republic will continue to be answered only once the answers have ceased to matter.

Investor obligations are another aspect of recent Indian practice that can help set a foundation for the new model. Under the India-Uzbekistan BIT, a state is expressly permitted to assert a counterclaim against an investor or investment. The new model can take a cue from this practice and lay down investor obligations and the circumstances in which counterclaims can be asserted.

The provision on dispute settlement also calls for reassessment. The five-year requirement to exhaust all judicial and administrative remedies under the 2015 Model could be assessed against the practices adopted by India since then. The three-year period for pursuing local remedies used in the India-UAE and India-Israel investment agreements shows greater flexibility in India’s approach. The Model BIT may also provide for more effective consultation and dispute-prevention procedures prior to arbitration, which are being discussed at UNCITRAL Working Group III.

Need for precision, clarity

The substantive protections should be equally precise. Clarity of language concerning expropriation and fair and equitable treatment (FET) could help avoid confusion in interpretation while safeguarding the right of the state to regulate for the public good. Sustainable development and responsible investment must not be left as policy declarations. Where India wishes to impose obligations on investors, those obligations should be expressed in clear legal terms. The changes need not make the new model uniformly more favourable either to investors or to states. The aim should be a model that is clearer, more workable and better suited to India’s position today, while allowing room for necessary adjustments in individual treaties.

With the revised model now reportedly finalised and awaiting Cabinet approval, the key question will be whether its final text adequately reflects the lessons of India’s treaty experience over the past decade while providing a coherent framework for future negotiations.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Service extensions

We have recently witnessed a trend of granting routine service extensions to senior bureaucrats, particularly State Chief Secretaries, Union Secretaries and other officials, beyond their superannuation, leaving aside officials of parastatal bodies. While governments often cite “administrative

exigencies” and the need for continuity, the long-term institutional costs can outweigh the short-term benefits, particularly when no compelling administrative necessity exists. As constitutional heads have pointed out in public forums, extending the tenure of retiring officers can demoralise the

administrative system and create an artificial bottleneck at the top, limiting the career progression of capable officers next in line. Keeping a select few officials in key positions for extended periods can also blur the line between professional administration and political alignment. There must be

merit-based succession. Alternatively, if experience and continued public service are considered essential, the retirement age could be raised to 62. **Sanjoy Das Sarma,** Kolkata
Making dissent visible
The sparse media coverage of the CJP protests on

October 2 raises a larger question about what the media chooses to make visible. The media must recognise that it is dealing with a Gen Z already showing signs of deep disillusionment with institutions and politics. When an important section of this generation takes to the streets, ignoring or

underplaying it does not make the issue disappear. It can instead reinforce the perception that both the media and the government are indifferent to their concerns. **R. Narayanan,** Navi Mumbai
Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO

Deleted, and left in limbo

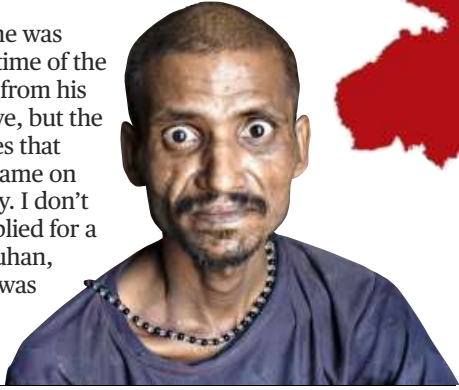
Across Bihar and West Bengal, lakhs of voters were deleted from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, leaving them unable to vote in the 2025 and 2026 Assembly elections. Over 47 lakh names were deleted in Bihar and nearly 91 lakh in West Bengal. **Shrabana Chatterjee** and **Senjuti Sengupta** met some of those affected, documenting the uncertainty, paperwork, and repeated attempts to prove their citizenship and eligibility that followed the deletions

Deepak Chauhan

35; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; currently unemployed

Reason for deletion: Absent

Chauhan, who is disabled, says he has no idea why he was deleted from the list. He says he was at home at the time of the the exercise and the booth-level officer (BLO) is also from his village. “The BLO knows that I live here and I am alive, but the BLO still marked me absent,” he says. Chauhan hopes that local volunteers and activists will be able to get his name on the list. “I live in a lot of pain because of my disability. I don’t know how to get my name back on the list. I had applied for a new [voter ID] card, but did not get it,” he says. Chauhan, who has never missed voting in an election, says he was unable to vote in the 2025 Bihar Assembly elections. He last voted in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls.



Sunil Sah

36; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; Border Security Force personnel

Reason for deletion: Already registered

Sah’s father says his son was not present during the SIR process to fill up the form. His family filled up the form, yet Sah’s name was struck off the list. “He is a government servant. He is serving the nation. And yet his vote has been taken away,” says Sah’s father. He adds that local activists are helping them fill up Form 6, so that Sah can be registered as a new voter. Sah did not come back from duty to vote in the 2025 elections because his name was deleted, says his father. “Otherwise, he always tries to come back to exercise his democratic right to vote,” he says.



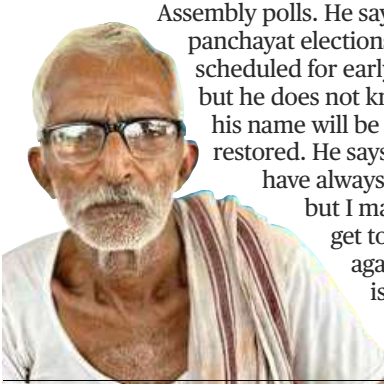
Ramashankar Sah

70; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; farmer

Reason for deletion: Already registered

Sah says he has never voted anywhere except in his own constituency. “The cause of deletion is ‘already registered’. Why did they remove my name? I don’t understand,” he says. He also says he had submitted all the documents. He has asked local officials for help, but no one has been able to give him an answer. Local activists are now helping him. Sah was unable to vote in the 2025 Bihar

Assembly polls. He says the panchayat elections are scheduled for early 2027, but he does not know if his name will be restored. He says: “I have always voted, but I may not get to vote again. How is that okay?”

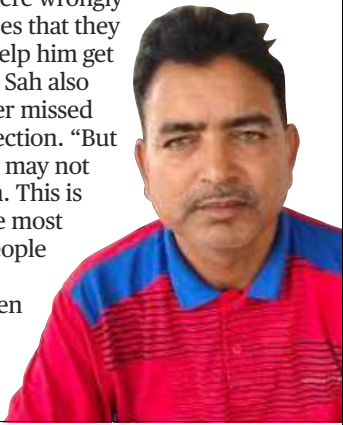


Shri Bhagwan Sah

52; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; farmer

Reason for deletion: Already registered

Sah says he has only one voter ID. “This feels like a targeted attack. My whole family was deleted for the same reason,” he says. Sah says only local political workers from the Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation are helping the family by conducting surveys to find out whose names were wrongly deleted. He hopes that they will be able to help him get back on the list. Sah also says he has never missed voting in any election. “But now I fear that I may not get to vote again. This is ‘vote chori’. The most marginalised people – SCs, STs, and OBCs – have been impacted by this,” he says.

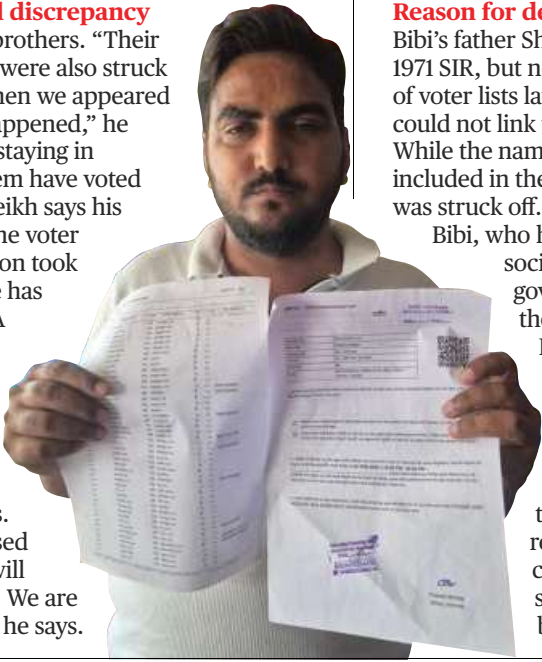


Md. Alauddin Sheikh

47; Samserganj constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; local politician who also contested in 2021

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Sheikh says he is one of three brothers. “Their names and their wives’ names were also struck off. We told the officers that when we appeared for the hearing. But nothing happened,” he says. Sheikh’s family has been staying in Samserganj for years. All of them have voted regularly over the decades. Sheikh says his great grandfather featured in the voter list of 1952 when the first election took place in independent India. He has appealed before the tribunal. A member of the Social Democratic Party of India in Murshidabad, he believes that the deletion is politically motivated. “The ruling government is excluding all the Muslim voters. Their intention has been exposed through this exercise. But we will resist them. We are not scared. We are all are Indian no matter what,” he says.



Hazera Bibi

33; Rejinagar constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; bidi worker

Reason for deletion: Unmapped

Bibi’s father Sheikh Haider Ali’s name was listed both in the 1995 and 1971 SIR, but not in the 2002 SIR. His name was included in revisions of voter lists later as a new voter. Therefore, Bibi and her siblings could not link their names with any relatives from the 2002 SIR list. While the names of her three siblings have been included in the latest SIR despite this gap, Bibi’s name was struck off. She has appealed before the tribunal.

Bibi, who had been availing herself of several social welfare schemes run by the State government, is no longer able to access them. Her benefits under the National Food Security Act have also been suspended. “I’ve been voting since 2019. Now the government seems to believe that I am not even a resident of this country and has snatched away my benefits,” she says.



Durgabati Devi

47; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; homemaker

Reason for deletion: Already registered

Devi says she had filled up all the forms that the BLO had provided. “I submitted the documents, I did everything that was asked of me. Yet they deleted my name without any reason,” she says. Devi has asked the local officials why her name was deleted and what she should do to get it restored, but again, no one has answers. She is unsure of whether she will ever be able to get back on the electoral rolls. Since her name is absent, Devi says she could not vote in 2025. “For a poor person like me, exercising my franchise is the only power I have in this country. That power has been taken away from me,” she says.

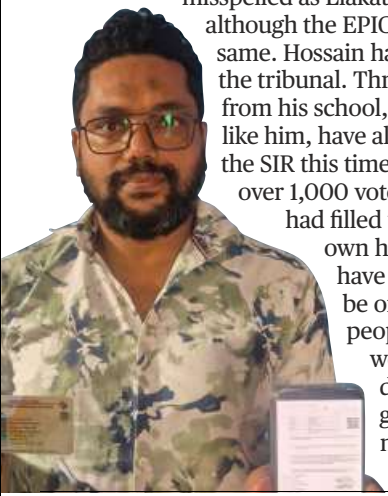


Md. Mojahar Hossain

39; Samserganj constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; school teacher who also served as a BLO during the SIR

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Six other people claimed Hossain’s father as their own in the 2002 SIR list. Hossain says he doesn’t have six siblings. “I have one sister and three brothers. The reason (for deletion) is terribly funny,” he says. While the names of his three brothers were included in the latest SIR, his sister’s and father’s names were also excluded. The Election Commission told his father, Liakat Hossain, that his name did not match the 2002 SIR list. Later, they found that his surname was misspelled as Liakat ‘Hosen’ in that list although the EPIC number was the same. Hossain has appealed before the tribunal. Three other teachers from his school, who served as BLOs like him, have also been excluded in the SIR this time. “I have surveyed over 1,000 voters in my booth. I had filled up my form with my own hand. Who would have thought that I would be one of those 300 people whose names would be excluded. I don’t know what is going to happen next,” he says.



S.K. Riaz

24; Medinipur constituency, Paschim Medinipur district, West Bengal; student

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Riaz says there was a discrepancy in his father’s name and that, because he had provided his father’s name to establish his link to the 2002 rolls during the mapping and form-filling process, his own name was also struck off. He says their cases were sent to the tribunal and are still under adjudication. “We have not heard back from officials on getting our names restored,” he says. Since every family member’s name was struck off the list, he says the family is not getting their rations. “We have gone to the officials at least six times and filled up multiple forms. Now we get some basic rations, but not the actual quantity we are entitled to. This feels like a targeted attack,” he says.



Rakesh Chauhan

36; Ziradei constituency, Siwan district, Bihar; labourer

Reason for deletion: Already registered

Chauhan says he had two voter cards because officials filled in the wrong details. This, he says, is what has led to him being included under the ‘already registered’ category. Now both the cards are invalid. “I have no idea how to get my name back on the rolls,” he says. “I have spoken to local gram panchayat leaders and officials. But I could not vote in 2025. I have two voter cards and not a single vote.” It is because of the officials’ mistake and not his that his voter rights have been taken away, he insists. “How is that okay when the fault was not even mine? This is such a mess,” he says.



Faruk Kazi

19; Rejinagar constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; labourer

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

Kazi’s parents’ names were not listed in the 2002 SIR as they had registered themselves as voters much later. During the survey, Kazi linked his name with his grandfather Hossain Ali whose name was on the 2002 list. All his family members found themselves back in the final voter list in the 2026 SIR, except Kazi. He has appealed before the tribunal. “I was excited to vote for the first time. My parents’ names and elder brother’s names were included in the SIR. I have no idea why my name was struck off,” says Kazi, who registered himself as a new voter only in 2025 and was supposed to cast his first vote in the 2026 Assembly elections. As no decision has been taken yet by the judicial officer in the tribunal, he will also not be able to vote in the upcoming by-poll on October 6.

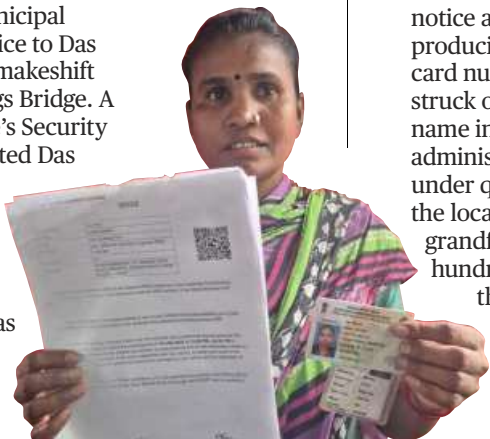


Rati Das

35; Kolkata, West Bengal; Kolkata Port constituency; ragpicker

Reason for deletion: Unmapped

Das is a first-generation voter in her family. Her father died when she was a child. After his death, her mother was driven out by her in-laws. Along with her two children, she occupied a pavement under Hastings Bridge in Khidirpur. Das does not have a permanent house. In 2012, she and her sister got themselves registered as voters and also started exercising their franchise in every election. But now both their names have been struck off as they failed to link themselves with any of their relatives on the 2002 list. Das has appealed before the tribunal. After the deletion, the Kolkata Municipal Corporation issued a notice to Das asking her to vacate her makeshift settlement under Hastings Bridge. A team from Kolkata Police’s Security Control Organisation visited Das and her sister last month and checked all their documents. “They asked me whether I came from Bangladesh. How will I prove that I was born and brought up in this city? Could you tell them that I am Indian?”



Md Shamim Akhtar

49; Entally constituency, Kolkata, West Bengal; Wing Commander (Retd), Indian Air Force

Reason for deletion: Unknown

Akhtar says he was not placed under any category. He says his name and his father’s name were both there in the 2002 voter list. He submitted all the documents, yet in February this year, his name came under adjudication, he says. “When the supplementary lists came out in March 2026, I saw that my name had been deleted. They did not even let me appear for a hearing or give me notice about how to solve the problem. I was struck off without any procedure,” he says. Akhtar worries that the BLO has stopped taking his calls. Neither he nor the BLO has any idea how to get his name restored, he says. “This is a complete violation of a person’s democratic right,” Akhtar adds. “Every person responsible for this should be tried for stripping us of our basic democratic right as a citizen of this country.”



Najmatara Khatoon

29; Samserganj constituency, Murshidabad district, West Bengal; Anganwadi worker

Reason for deletion: Logical discrepancy

The name of Khatoon’s father, Abdul Haq, was listed as Abdul Haq Sheikh in the 2002 SIR. Due to the mismatch, she was issued a notice and asked to appear for a hearing. Despite producing all the documents, including her father’s EPIC card number that matched the 2002 list, her name was struck off. She appealed before the tribunal to have her name included. “When I approached the local district administration officers, they said my nationality is under question,” she says. “I have been serving in the local Anganwadi for years. My great grandfather built our home over a hundred years ago. How dare they say that I am not Indian?”



Photo credits: Shrabana Chatterjee and Senjuti Sengupta. Emails: shrabana.chatterjee@thehindu.co.in; senjuti.sengupta@thehindu.co.in

ANDHRA PRADESH



Children play close to makeshift shelters, pieced together from frayed plastic sheets and tarpaulins, at Prabhu Nagar in Poranki, on the outskirts of Vijayawada. G.N. RAO

Fighting a quiet battle for dignity, belonging

Caught in a relentless cycle of landlessness, insecure housing, precarious livelihoods, and neglect, the Yanadi and Chenchu settlements in Andhra Pradesh remain profoundly marginalised. Despite many government welfare schemes aimed at uplifting these communities, a stark divide persists between their living conditions and the surrounding urban localities, writes **P. Sujatha Varma**

On one side lies the bustle of Poranki Centre in Vijayawada city, where gridlocked traffic, thriving shops, and a sprawling residential colony dictate the rhythms of everyday life. On the other, about 40 Yanadi families are living in a world completely detached from urban civilisation. Though separated by barely a few kilometres, the true distance between these two worlds is measured in their access to education, healthcare, secure livelihoods, and basic amenities.

Poranki, a prominent neighbourhood within the Penamaluru mandal of the Vijayawada revenue division, contains pockets where contrasting realities exist side by side. In Prabhu Nagar, a spacious residential area reached by a narrow lane branching off the main thoroughfare, the contrast becomes stark just beyond a pre-primary Anganwadi centre.

Here, a pathway covered in mud and slush gives way to a cramped, filthy alley of makeshift shelters. Pieced together from frayed plastic sheets and tarpaulins, these dwellings lack even basic doors or windows. A short walk through this landscape reveals children running barefoot through the muck, and women sitting on iron cots outside their shelters—some quietly combing their hair, others talking in hushed tones. There is little movement here, and even less cheer. It is a settlement suspended in a state of deprivation, despite being within easy reach of the mainstream world.

The true depth of the families’ predicament becomes clear within minutes. Their makeshift shelters sit precariously on a small portion of private land that doubles as a Christian burial ground. A few graves lie startlingly close to the dwellings. Pointing toward one of the weathered mounds, Thupakula Pottamma, a woman in her fifties, quietly says it is where her mother-in-law was buried a few years ago. “We live where the dead rest. We too will join them when we die,” she says, her voice choking.

Making matters worse, the landowners have repeatedly asked the families to vacate the property. Yet, the residents insist they have nowhere else to go. Over the years, they have knocked on the doors of local officials and ruling party leaders, pleading for a piece of land where they can finally relocate and build secure lives.

“Years have passed, but no alternative has materialised,” says Subbamma. “The one time we pressed for a solution, the authorities said they would shift us to either Onkuru or Pulipaka. But it seemed like they were only saying that to ward us off,” she adds.

Slushy pathways

And their problems don’t end there. When it rains, the settlement is quickly inundated, forcing the families to take shelter in the Anganwadi building or in the cellar of a nearby apartment complex, an arrangement facilitated by a local TDP leader.

“The pathway to our homes become so slushy that we can hardly walk on it. After repeated requests, the local authorities laid gravel on it, but the recent heavy rains washed it all away. There



Years have passed, but no alternative has materialised. The one time we pressed for a solution, the authorities said they would shift us to either Onkuru or Pulipaka. But it seemed like they were only saying that to ward us off.

SUBBAMMA
Resident of
Prabhu Nagar

is no sign of the gravel now,” says Durga Bhavani, pointing to the muddy, slush-filled pathway.

Another problem is that no one in the community, young or old, seems to know their age. “I don’t know. It is mentioned on my Aadhaar card, which I got only recently,” says Eega Eeswar, who looks barely old enough to be the father of three children.

For a living, the men go fishing in the nearby canals or scavenging for recyclable waste, while some of the women venture out to collect waste to supplement the meagre household income. Even before the break of dawn, they go out, rummaging around for plastic, tins, metal pieces, and other discarded material to make anywhere between ₹200 and ₹300 by selling them to the local scrap dealer.

For children in the settlement, the divide begins early, making education a distant dream. However, intervention by a local NGO has helped a few children enrol in the nearby Zilla Parishad school, offering them a chance to break out of the cycle of deprivation.

“It took us a long time to persuade the families to send their children to school. They take time to trust outsiders,” says Vasantha Kumari from Navajeevan Bala Bhavan (NJB), an NGO working for the rescue and rehabilitation of children and youth from troubled background.

For Lakshmi, that trust has transformed into a sense of pride. Watching her 11-year-old daughter, Charmudi, return home in a school uniform alongside a few other children, her face lights up. “She is very talented,” Lakshmi says softly. “She even won first prize in a drawing competition.”

In a settlement otherwise defined by deprivation, Charmudi’s success, and her mother’s quiet pride, stand as living proof of what can be achieved if only the children here are given an equal opportunity.

The lack of access is also evident inside these dark, dingy dwellings, which contain little beyond the bare essentials—such as iron cots, a few cooking utensils, and, in some dwellings, old wooden tables piled with used clothes and other

belongings. Each shelter has a bulb, but electricity is available only from 6 p.m. to 6 a.m. A couple of solar lights donated by the NGO in the common area provide some relief, allowing the children to sit outside and do their homework after dusk.

Life continues

The picture is much the same across the plains of Andhra Pradesh, with several Yanadi settlements caught between insecure housing, precarious livelihoods, and poor access to basic amenities, even when they are located within or close to expanding urban and semi-urban settlements.

“The Yanadis are a historically mobile community, with Reddy Yanadis generally better off and Challa Yanadis among the more impoverished sections. Their problems are particularly acute in the plains, where many continue to live on the margins of society,” says Alladi Deva Kumar, founder and executive secretary of Dalit Bahujan Resource Centre that works to empower marginalised communities.

One of the most serious concerns, he says, is the lack of institutional deliveries among Yanadi women. “With many children born outside formal healthcare facilities, securing birth certificates and Aadhaar cards becomes difficult. The absence of identity documents, in turn, can prevent children from enrolling in schools and accessing various government welfare schemes,” says Deva Kumar.



With many children born outside formal healthcare facilities, securing birth certificates and Aadhaar cards becomes difficult.

ALLADI DEVA KUMAR
Founder of Dalit Bahujan
Resource Centre

decades, he says the colony lacks drinking water, sanitation, and toilets, while 37 children have no Anganwadi facility and 55 students have to travel 3 km to attend school. As many as 130 families continue to live in makeshift tents.

If the Yanadi experience illustrates the vulnerability of a historically mobile community in the plains, the experience of the Chenchus points to another dimension of tribal displacement: the movement of a forest-dependent Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group (PVTG) community toward the fringes of towns and cities.

Although Chenchus’ vulnerability is officially recognised through their classification as a PVTG community, many of them, after being pushed out of their habitats in forests, have moved to the fringes of towns and cities, where the loss of traditional livelihoods has not necessarily translated into better access to housing, education, healthcare, and other services.

A stark manifestation of this crisis unfolded nearly a decade ago at B.B.R. Nagar in Kankipadu, Krishna district. Today, a row of makeshift shelters lines the main thoroughfare—a settlement that surfaced after about 20 Chenchu families were driven out of a nearby locality by residents who demanded their removal from the area. “The good thing about this place is that it is beside the canal, where our men can catch fish. But living here has its own challenges. We have put up temporary shelters, but rainwater drips through the roof during the monsoon, and snakes and other creatures also get inside because there is no proper flooring,” says Avala Sivamma, a mother of three. Sivamma, who works as a domestic helper in a few households in the nearby localities, does her best to keep the family going and put food on the table, as whatever little her husband earns through fishing is spent on alcohol.

Despite their living challenges, the 20 households have managed to obtain a public tap for wa-

ter supply. Earlier, their children, who went to school without taking a bath for want of water, were sent back by teachers who asked them to bathe and come. Housing is another major concern. “Grant of pattas for the land we occupy will solve our major problem,” says Mariyamma, a mother of three.

For activists working with these communities, however, the problem goes beyond the immediate deficits in housing, land, and basic services. It also raises questions about political representation and the ability of fragmented communities to articulate a common demand.

“Along with the Denotified Tribes (DNTs), the communities that were historically brought under the colonial Criminal Tribes Acts and subsequently denotified after Independence, it is true that Scheduled Tribes like Yanadis and Chenchus have also faced severe socio-economic vulnerability,” says M. Subba Rao, an activist fighting for DNT rights for the last three decades.

Political representation of the communities, he says, is the only way out. “Lack of political maturity has kept fragmented social and political groups belonging to these communities from uniting for a common cause,” he says ruefully, alleging that some activists seek proximity to upper-caste power centres, which exploit divisions among DNT communities and leaders to retain their influence.

On paper and reality

The scale of the challenge is reflected in the State’s own data on its most vulnerable tribal communities. Andhra Pradesh has a total population of 4,95,77,700, of which the ST population is 27,39,504 (5.53%). According to the 2023 PVTG survey, the State had a PVTG population of 4,88,329, comprising 1,28,663 PVTG households belonging to 11 communities, including Chenchu, Bodo Gadaba, Guto Gadaba, Kondareddi, Dongria Khond, Kutia Khond, Bondo Porja, Khond Porja, Parangi Porja, Konda Savaras, and Kolam.

Several government initiatives have sought to address these shortcomings. The State Tribal Welfare Department officials say efforts are being made to improve the socio-economic status of PVTGs by bridging gaps in health, education, and livelihoods, and by saturating PVTG communities and families with basic facilities and services under the Central scheme PM-JANMAN (Pradhan Mantri Janjati Adivasi Nyaya Maha Abhiyan).

According to officials, the scheme is being implemented through 11 interventions, including housing, roads, drinking water, healthcare, education, electrification, mobile connectivity, and livelihood support. Under the housing component, 43,593 houses have been sanctioned against 50,636 identified gaps, with 11,074 completed. For road connectivity, 303 works covering 866 km have been sanctioned to connect 341 habitations, of which 132 km has been completed.

The officials claim that under piped water supply, 99,865 of 1.80 lakh PVTG households have been provided tap connections, achieving 55.54% coverage, with works sanctioned for another 500 habitations. Healthcare is being provided through 156 Mobile Medical Units covering all the PVTG habitations. “The Government is also trying to reach out to the ST population through Dharti Aaba Janjatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan (DA-JGUA),” said the department’s Additional Director M. Saraswathi. Despite the existence of schemes aimed at uplifting ST, PVTG and DNT communities, many continue to face issues involving landlessness, casual labour, insecure housing, education, documentation, access to welfare and integration into society.

Scattered settlements along canals and tank bunds and on the fringes of villages and towns may be located close to mainstream residential areas, but they face severe isolation. The question is not merely whether government schemes reach tribal communities, but whether the schemes are designed around the way those communities actually live.



Charmudi immersed in her school work while sitting outside her shelter at Prabhu Nagar in Poranki. G.N. RAO

KERALAM



Long wait: With the State government introducing the Priyadarshini free travel scheme, women passengers have nearly abandoned private buses. A private bus that runs on the East Fort-Peroorkada route in Thiruvananthapuram. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

A Bumpy Ride

While the Priyadarshini free travel scheme has brought cheers to women passengers, it has dealt a body blow to the private bus sector. **Dhinesh Kallungal** speaks to stakeholders to understand the crisis in the sector

It was raining intermittently on a cloudy evening when a private bus on the Attingal-Venjaramoodu route entered the crowded Attingal private bus stand in Thiruvananthapuram in Kerala.

Even before the engine fell silent, the bus crew spotted another bus at the stand—a service that, according to the route schedule, should have left the stand around 30 seconds ago. Within moments, a heated argument began between the crew of the two buses. The crew of the former bus alleged that the latter bus was eating into their business by deliberately delaying its departure and poaching passengers. After several minutes of heated exchanges, the latter bus finally left the stand, with only a handful of passengers.

Though that confrontation ended there, another, milder altercation erupted inside the former bus. The owner-turned-conductor directed his frustration towards the driver. Throughout the journey, the conductor had repeatedly urged the driver to speed through the heavy evening traffic, skip some stops and ensure that the bus reached the stand on schedule.

K.N. Rajesh (name changed), a middle-aged driver with around 22 years of experience at the wheel, said no amount of skill acquired over the years could have helped him beat the heavy evening traffic in the town and the delay was unavoidable. Yet, the bus had lost a handful of passengers as it arrived about 30 seconds late. The delay will cause a cascading effect on passenger numbers at nearly half the stops along the route, he says.

“As bus workers, we try to avoid such situations. In our bid to maintain time and minimise losses, we may inadvertently commit minor traffic violations such as jumping a red signal at the last moment or skipping certain stops or services,” says Rajesh.

Worsening situation

The episode offers a glimpse into the daily dramas unfolding across Keralam’s public transport network, where intense competition, fuelled by dwindling revenues of private bus operators, has become commonplace. The situation has worsened since the State government introduced the Priyadarshini free travel scheme on Ordinary buses of the Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) for women and transgender persons on June 15, 2026.

State should increase minimum fare to ₹15 and hike student fares, or private bus sector will face a slow death.

T. GOPINATHAN
General secretary,
All Kerala Bus
Operators
Organisation

Janatha Sabu, a private bus owner and member of the Kerala Motor Transport Workers’ Welfare Fund Board, notes that the industry has been in the doldrums since the COVID-19 outbreak, with nearly a third of its passenger base switching to alternative modes of transport. The Priyadarshini scheme has now dealt another severe blow to the already struggling private bus industry, eroding more than 50% of its existing passenger base, observes Sabu.

The resulting scramble for getting passengers has intensified competition and turned bus stands across the State into venues of frequent confrontations. The scheme, a poll promise of the United Democratic Front, has now emerged as a major success, with women passengers embracing the scheme. Transport Minister C.P. John says the scheme had facilitated an average 12.93 lakh free journeys a day in 100 days, entailing a financial liability of around ₹267 crore for the KSRTC.

While acknowledging the scheme’s popularity, the private bus operators say they are not entirely opposed to it, even though it had severely affected their livelihood.

Called off operations

T. Gopinathan, general secretary of the All Kerala Bus Operators Organisation, says that around 700 private buses had ceased operations during the first 100 days of the scheme. More than half of the buses still in operation are reportedly running reduced services and earning low daily revenues.

“The State government should hike the minimum fare to ₹15 for all categories of passengers, along with an increase in student fares, to offset the losses suffered by private buses. Otherwise, the private bus sector will face a slow death,” says Gopinathan.

Daily revenue has fallen by around ₹2,000 to ₹3,000 for private buses operating in southern Keralam, where KSRTC services are more extensive than in the central and northern parts of the State.

Many operators are left with barely ₹500 to

₹1,000 in daily profit after meeting fuel expenses, employees’ wages and maintenance costs. Fuel prices alone have risen by around ₹9 a litre following the West Asia crisis, observes Sabu, who operates three buses.

An interesting anecdote about Kerala’s private bus industry is closely intertwined with the State’s enduring tea culture. Sunil Kumar, owner of Saroma Travels, which once operated a fleet of 10 buses but now runs only four services in Thiruvananthapuram city, recalls the long-standing relationship between the price of a cup of tea and the minimum bus fare. “When I entered the industry in 1994, the minimum bus fare was ₹1, and a cup of tea too cost ₹1. By 1996, both had risen to ₹2, and they continued to rise together at regular intervals,” he recalls.

Just before the introduction of the Priyadarshini scheme, the minimum private bus fare in Keralam was ₹10, so was the price of a cup of tea. But things changed after the West Asia war. While the tea prices rose to ₹15 across the State, the minimum bus fare remained unchanged despite a sharp increase in fuel prices and other operational costs, including price of spare parts and accessories.

“Besides these increases, the State government’s free-travel scheme came as a body blow to the industry that has already been struggling to survive,” Kumar says.

Lower income, higher expense

Private bus revenues have also failed to keep pace with the rise in the consumer price index over the years. The disparity is evident from the experience of Shaji, a bus owner and office-bearer of the Kerala Private Bus Federation. “Fifteen years ago, the minimum bus fare was ₹5, and a single bus generated ₹7,000-₹8,000 in revenue a day. Even today, buses on the most profitable routes earn only around ₹9,000 to ₹10,000 a day. The interesting part is that diesel that cost ₹35 a litre 15 years ago costs ₹104 today. The daily wage of bus crew has risen from ₹300 to around ₹1,100 during the same period,” explains Shaji.

The plight of bus crew members is even more distressing. An average crew member begins the day around 5 a.m., with most private buses starting services between 5.30 a.m. and 6.30 a.m. The workday often stretches until 9 p.m. or 10 p.m., making for 12-15-hour shifts.

Crew members who once earned around ₹1,100 to ₹1,200 a day often receive only ₹700 to ₹800 on less profitable routes because of falling revenues.

Rajesh G., who has worked as a private bus conductor on the Irinjalakuda-Tripprayar route for the past 24 years, says the demanding work schedule bears little relation to the remuneration. “The only reason many of us continue in this profession is that we do not possess any other skills or means to support our families. During the COVID-19 pandemic, I tried selling lottery tickets on the streets to make a living, but the income was not enough to support my family. That eventually forced me back into the only profession I know,” Rajesh sighs.

Happy women

On the other hand, the latest turn of events has brought cheer to women across Keralam, although the major beneficiaries of the free-ride scheme are those in southern Keralam and parts of central Keralam. According to Deepa M., a native of Kallambalam and a private-sector employee, the scheme has been a boon, particularly for women working in low-paying jobs in textile shops, sales and other unorganised sectors. “Saving an average of ₹1,000 to ₹1,800 a month means a lot to an ordinary homemaker,” she feels.

However, she points out that the scheme has its drawbacks too. “My son studies in a school in Sreekeyam, Thiruvananthapuram. He travels from Kallambalam to Sreekeyam, a route where KSRTC enjoys a virtual monopoly. Student concession is available only on KSRTC Ordinary buses, which are now overcrowded with women passengers, forcing him to travel on KSRTC Fast Passenger buses, which do not offer student concession. Whatever I save through the free-ride scheme is lost on my son’s daily commute,” Deepa says.

The major grievance of private bus operators is the manner in which the State government implemented the scheme without introducing measures to shield the private bus sector from its adverse impact.

The government could have extended the scheme to private buses as well. An income-based scheme applicable to both the KSRTC and private buses would ensure that economically weaker sections continue to receive the benefits while also supporting the student community, feel bus operators.

“Such a model would reduce pressure on routes inadequately served by the KSRTC and enable the State to extend the benefit to people across Keralam by making optimum use of the existing public transport network,” feels Gopinathan.

An expert committee headed by former Transport Commissioner K. Padmakumar has submitted a report to Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan recommending several measures to address the concerns of private buses numbering around 11,000, including according the sector industry status. However, private bus operators have rejected most of the recommendations, saying they do little to address their immediate concerns.

The road ahead remains uncertain for the private bus operators.



Preferred choice: Women boarding a KSRTC bus in Kochi after the launch of the Priyadarshini free travel scheme. H. VIBHU



Medicines typically pass through manufacturers, clearing and forwarding agents, stockists, sub-stockists, and retailers before reaching a patient; each handover creates an opportunity for pilferage. ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

the reputation of the manufacturer. The packaging and labelling can also throw up red flags.”

He says while it is not a perfect system, hospitals do what they can to ensure that medicines are genuine. “Ideally, the government should facilitate more sampling and have more testing labs. The onus can only be on the government to make these checks. It isn’t possible for individual hospitals to do actual quality checks,” he says.

Dr. Shyam Agarwal, chairperson of the Department of Medical Oncology at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, says when a patient reports that a medicine is not effective, doctors cannot establish whether the medicine itself is to blame.

“One way to avoid counterfeits is to ensure that the supply coming into hospitals is from genuine companies and that they are not offering steep discounts. A 50% discount should raise suspicion,” he says.

A broken chain

While investigations have traced the chain in such cases, the implications for patients are rarely known. Patients find it almost impossible to establish whether they have consumed a counterfeit medicine. In the case of the rabies vaccine, for instance, a government official says, “It is hard to trace how many patients have consumed it, and from where. If we circulate notices warning patients about a particular medicine, it might lead to more panic.”

The official adds that one way to check whether a patient has received a counterfeit medicine is to trace the batch number recorded on the bill.

Patient rights advocate Bejon Kumar Misra points out that there are not enough large-scale studies to ascertain the impact of counterfeit medicines and that even when data is recorded, it is rarely traced back to patients. “One of the major causes of the issue is that the lowest bidder ends up getting preference,” he says.



Investigators found original cartons and empty boxes being retained and reused. Batch numbers, MRP details, and other identifying marks were allegedly removed with chemicals like acetone before the medicines were repackaged

ADITYA GAUTAM
DCP, Crime Branch, Delhi Police

He adds that while many patients are affected, many do not even realise they have consumed counterfeit medicines and that the medicines are not working.

According to government data, drug regulators tested 1,41,322 samples across India in 2025-26. Of these, 3,012 were declared ‘Not of Standard Quality’ and 283 were found to be spurious or adulterated. State drug regulators initiated 779 prosecution cases for the manufacture, sale, and distribution of spurious or adulterated drugs.

When medicines fail silently

The consequences are most serious when the failure is not immediately visible.

In cancer treatment, a counterfeit or substandard medicine may contain too little or none of the active ingredients needed to work. A patient may continue treatment believing therapy is being administered while the disease progresses. The delay in detecting treatment failure makes oncology one of the areas most affected by counterfeit medicines, Varma says. With emergency or other life-saving medicines, the consequences can be immediate. Incorrect ingredients or contamination can also cause harm independent of the illness being treated.

For the health industry, the damage extends beyond the patient. Manufacturers can face lost sales and complaints over products they did not make; legitimate distributors and pharmacies bear the cost of investigations and recalls; and repeated counterfeit incidents can erode confidence in genuine medicines and India’s pharmaceutical supply chain.

The answer has to move beyond periodic enforcement, Varma says. Manufacturers need tighter accounting of unused and returned vials, hospitals need records of who receives high-value injections and how empty vials are disposed of, and wholesalers and pharmacies need to conduct stronger checks on suppliers and maintain traceable purchase records.

The fear of fake

Every time Jharana Mallick, 32, who has thalassemia, goes to buy iron chelator medicines, she is careful about which company she picks and medical store she buys from, hoping she does not have to relive what happened 10 years ago.

“For a whole year, the medicines I bought from dispensaries had no effect. After five or six tests, I realised my serum ferritin levels were going up rather than coming down. And I simultaneously started developing issues like osteoporosis and even a gall bladder stone,” she says.

Originally from Odisha, she now lives in Delhi and undergoes frequent blood transfusions. Her mistrust extends beyond the medicines to the system itself. “These are supposed to be life-saving drugs, but they are bought at the lowest tendering costs,” says Mallick, who now works with a charitable trust, Sarvesham Mangalam Foundation, focussed on thalassemia awareness and prevention. In a month, she says, people living with thalassemia can spend up to ₹50,000 on drugs.

Doctors never told her that the medicines she took were counterfeit, she says. But the experience left her with a demand that goes beyond her own treatment: the system should stop “compromising on life-saving drugs”.

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salers, brokers, and pharmacists.

Paperwork is another layer of camouflage. The police say invoices are generated for medicines that were never actually supplied, creating a paper trail for illicit transactions. In one instance, investigators found amounts routed through a firm’s bank account and, after GST and commission were deducted, the balance returned in cash. Registers and diaries recording medicine transactions and cash dealings were also recovered. The total turnover and profit from the illicit trade are still being worked out.

Medicines typically pass through manufacturers, clearing and forwarding agents, stockists, sub-stockists, and retailers before reaching a patient. Each handover creates an opportunity for pilferage, according to the police.

“Indian laws require purchase and sale records at every stage, but an invoice only attests that a transaction occurred; it does not ensure that the product inside the box matches its label,” says Nilaya Varma, Group CEO of Primus Partners. “That loophole is precisely where counterfeiters operate,” he adds.

Manufacturing and packaging can be particularly difficult to police, he says, because convincing labels, copied batch numbers, holograms, and reused original packaging can defeat visual inspection. At the wholesale level, multiple transfers can further blur a product’s source, allowing suspect stock to mix with genuine medicines. A pharmacist may be able to check the brand and batch number, but cannot establish the history of an individual pack.

Technology has added another layer of protection, but not an infallible one. India has required barcodes or QR codes on around 300 specified brands since August 2023, but a code that is merely scanned is not necessarily proof of provenance. “A copied or cloned code will pass a visual or app-based scan just as readily,” Varma says, arguing that verification against the manufacturer’s own database at the point of sale would provide a stronger safeguard.

The scale of the pharmaceutical market also limits the reach of testing. The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation and State drug regulators tested 1,16,323 samples in 2024-25, of which 245 were declared spurious or adulterated.

According to the government, more than 960 drug manufacturing premises have undergone risk-based inspections, resulting in over 860 regulatory actions.

Varma says regulators cannot physically examine every pack moving through more than 8.5 lakh retail pharmacies. “Sampling is a backstop that identifies a bad batch after the fact,” he says. “It cannot certify the pack in a patient’s hand at the moment of sale.”

The Crime Branch is still tracing the complete downstream chain, including pharmacies, distributors, end beneficiaries, and the financial trail. The number of patients who may have received counterfeit medicines, and any confirmed adverse health consequences, has not yet been established.

The lowest bidder

The wider supply chain also raises questions about how medicines enter hospitals in the first place. Lower tendering costs are among the causes, say doctors in Delhi, particularly those working in government settings.

Hospitals have drug and therapeutics committees that select and regulate the medicines brought into the premises. They point out that government directives require medicines to be procured from the lowest bidder, and if a hospital has not done so, it is expected to explain why.

Dr. Sumit Ray, Medical Director of Holy Family Hospital in Okhla, Delhi, a hospital run by a charitable trust, says the committee he chairs decides which medicines are selected. “It is difficult to prevent such medicines from entering the system, but there can be multiple levels of checks. For instance, if it is a new pharmaceutical company, we check which other hospitals it has supplied to, who its manufacturers are, and what is

person is a long and expensive process, so it is seldom done.

Medicine raids

In May this year, spurious oxytocin injections in government hospitals in Rajasthan’s Kota were a major reason for the deaths of five women following caesarean-section deliveries. The same batch of spurious oxytocin had reached Delhi government hospitals too, sources say, after which it was seized by the Drugs Control Department.

Five days after the inter-State drug raid that seized cancer medicines, the Crime Branch, in a separate investigation, arrested Dr. Manish Sharma, 39, a resident of Faridabad in Haryana, for allegedly selling smuggled, suspected adulterated, and counterfeit life-saving drugs.

According to the police, Sharma had gone to Russia to study medicine and returned to India in 2014. He later worked at a hospital in Faridabad before opening his own hospitals. After those ventures shut down, he and his wife started a polyclinic in the city. Sharma also registered HK Pharmaceuticals at the same address and began selling medicines on an e-commerce platform.

The police claim that he began sourcing medicines through illegal channels and selling them to buyers online. Last month, the Drugs Control Department seized counterfeit anti-rabies vaccine worth ₹2 lakh from Chandni Chowk’s Bhagirath Palace. A government official says the department acted on a tip-off and sent the vaccine to a testing centre in Himachal Pradesh’s Kasauli.

The problem of counterfeit drugs is not new. During the COVID-19 pandemic in 2021, the Crime Branch busted a facility allegedly manufacturing fake Remdesivir. At the time, hospitals were prescribing Remdesivir for COVID-19 and families were pooling savings to procure it, with one vial selling for as much as ₹90,000.

In 2022, spurious medicines valued at over ₹5 crore were seized from a factory at Tronica City in Uttar Pradesh’s Ghaziabad district. In 2024, investigators detected vials resembling high-value cancer drugs. Investigators are examining possible links between some of these and the present inter-State network, but no definitive connection has been established so far.

Labels stripped away

According to Crime Branch officials, medicines may reach people in different ways: counterfeit drugs made in warehouses, often made to look genuine; genuine medicines illegally diverted from the chain for which they were procured, such as drugs from a government hospital being diverted to the open market; and unauthorised medicines that are genuine but not legally approved or permitted for sale in India.

Once a medicine is tainted, either because it is spurious or has been removed from its legitimate supply chain, it moves through layers of intermediaries across States. Some are stored in homes or warehouses before being passed on to whole-



The government should facilitate more sampling and have more testing labs. The onus can only be on the government to make these checks. It isn’t possible for individual hospitals to do actual quality checks

DR. SUMIT RAY
Medical Director,
Holy Family
Hospital, Delhi

Over the past few months, probe agencies have busted several major drug rackets involving counterfeit and adulterated pharmaceuticals, from cancer treatments and vaccines to antibiotics and psychotropic drugs. **Lavpreet Kaur** and **Ashna Butani** trace how fakes move through illicit supply chains and find that while many perpetrators may be caught, there is no system for tracking down victims at the receiving end

Rajkumari and Darshan, both in their mid-30s and from Jharkhand, are leaving Delhi’s All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) after a check-up. They pause to collect themselves before navigating the medical stores outside. Rajkumari hangs on to her husband, who lugs an oversized bag that weighs him down. They have been given a list of medicines to buy.

Rajkumari was diagnosed with blood cancer about 10 months ago and referred to AIIMS for treatment. Since then, the couple has spent a large part of its savings on medicines, travel, and stay in Delhi. Darshan says he has sold their land to keep paying for the medicines.

He pulls out her prescription and points to a name. A single injection of the medicine costs around ₹1.5 lakh and his wife will need several vials. The drug is used in the treatment of blood and bone marrow cancers, including multiple myeloma. It is also among the high-value cancer medicines that figure in an investigation by Delhi Police’s Inter-State Cell into counterfeit and illegally diverted drugs. The racket, spread across Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Telangana, was busted in late August.

Aditya Gautam, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Crime Branch, says Delhi Police has so far arrested 17 people and recovered 588 filled vials and 3,021 other medicines, all valued at about ₹9 crore. “Investigators found original cartons and empty boxes being retained and reused. Batch numbers, MRP details, and other identifying marks were allegedly removed with chemicals like acetone before the medicines were repackaged,” he says.

The seized cancer drugs include Darzalex, Imfinzi, Erbitux, Opdivy, Gazvya, Bavencio, Adcetris, and Keytruda. Bavencio and Adcetris have been confirmed as counterfeit by the manufacturers; reports on the others are awaited.

A doctor at AIIMS involved in Rajkumari’s treatment says a red flag for a counterfeit drug is when it shows no results. He also says large discounts on drugs may indicate they are fake.

People pour in from across the country to Delhi for medical treatment.

In 2022, the national capital had nine Joint Commission International-accredited hospitals, meaning they meet global standards of clinical excellence. This is the highest number in the country, making Delhi a medical hub. This also brings with it the problem of counterfeit drugs.

Every month, Delhi Police and the Delhi Drugs Control Department report seizures of medicines they describe as “counterfeit, spurious, adulterated, illegally diverted or unauthorised”.

Substances seized range from basic allergy and skin treatment drugs to high-value cancer medicines, antibiotics, vaccines, and other life-saving pharmaceuticals.

Unless the operations are large, news of these raids and the names of the medicines seized seldom reach people. Tracing a fake medicine to a

CM
YK

GENEVA

At least 5,700 killed or wounded in Haiti gang violence this year: UN



Haiti's gang violence crisis has left at least 5,700 people dead or wounded this year while more than 1,000 women and girls have been raped, UN rights chief Volker Turk said on Friday. He said the casualties and rapes and 230 kidnappings had been recorded by the UN mission in Haiti up to September 11. AFP

KYIV

Ukraine denies facing crisis with F-16 over maintenance and parts



Ukraine on Friday denied that it was facing maintenance and supply problems with its F-16 fighter jets, insisting that it can keep them in the air throughout winter. The Wall Street Journal reported this week that delays in maintenance and a shortage of parts had grounded more than half of Ukraine's fleet. AFP

WASHINGTON

FBI arrests U.S. govt. employee for 'trying to support Yemeni Houthis'



The U.S. Justice Department said on Thursday that Ashton Hamed Ellaboudy, a Department of Energy electrical engineer, has been arrested by the Federal Bureau of Investigation on charges of providing support to the Houthis rebels, including by buying materials for home-made explosives and travelling to Yemen. AP

PARIS

BAPS says it didn't ask Eiffel Tower to remove women employees



The BAPS (Bochasanwasi Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha) has said investigations have established it did not request female employees be "removed or excluded" during its delegation's visit to the Eiffel Tower in Paris. The group reiterated its concern for employees affected by the events surrounding the visit. PTI

Russian strikes snarl traffic on Kyiv bridges in a new disruption tactic

Russian aerial attacks overnight force full or partial closure of three of Kyiv's six road bridges across the Dnipro river; Ukraine's Foreign Minister says Kyiv has received separate partial-truce proposals from the U.S., India, Turkiye, and Egypt

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian aerial attacks forced the partial closure on Friday of three bridges across the Dnipro river in Kyiv, the Ukrainian capital's Mayor said, in Moscow's latest effort to disrupt life in the city.

Meanwhile, Ukraine's top diplomat said officials have received separate proposals for a partial truce with Russia from the United States, India, Turkey, and Egypt. The proposals envision halting attacks on energy infrastructure which have caused fuel shortages in Russia and power outages



Choked roads: Cars stuck in a traffic jam near a bridge in Kyiv following overnight jet drone strikes on Friday. REUTERS

in Ukraine, and on Black Sea shipping needed to get vital grain exports to world markets.

The Russian strikes forcing the full or partial closure of three of Kyiv's six

road bridges caused traffic logjams and appeared to be a new tactic in its campaign to torment the city's residents. Previously, Russia has hit apartment blocks, supermarket ware-

houses, gas stations, data centres, and other targets, in an escalation of attacks.

Civilians "are bearing the brunt of this war", the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights, Volker Turk, said in Geneva on Friday.

"The war in Ukraine is a human rights catastrophe that is growing and intensifying by the week, causing unfathomable pain to civilians," he said. "Across Ukraine, people are living in constant dread."

Russia fired more than 100 drones at Ukraine overnight, striking Kyiv and eight other regions, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said. Almost half of the drones

were the jet-powered type that are especially hard to stop, he said.

A drone hit a high-rise apartment block in Kyiv, killing one person, he said. At least four people were reported wounded elsewhere.

Mr. Zelenskyy repeated his appeal for foreign countries to close loopholes in international sanctions on Russia and to add more restrictions on its trade.

He said Russia's drones and missiles are "critically dependent" on foreign components.

"Every Russian drone can actually be stopped right at the production line," Mr. Zelenskyy said.

G7 nations agree to release 100 million barrels of oil

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

The Group of Seven industrial nations said on Friday that they plan to release 100 million barrels of oil and fuel products in the coming weeks, starting with "substantial" amounts of diesel after the fuel recently hit record high prices in the United States.

President Donald Trump said the diesel release would happen "immediately," while a G7 statement promised a "front-loaded substantial release" of diesel within the next 20 days.

Mr. Trump and his Republican Party face pressure to address surging prices ahead of the November 3 midterm elections, and Mr. Trump announced the action on Friday on so-



Emmanuel Macron

cial media. The President's approval ratings on the economy hit a new low, according to an AP-NORC poll, as the Iran war and his trade battles have increased U.S. prices for oil and other goods.

Record high

Fuel prices in the U.S. and abroad have soared during the eight-month-long war, a cost Mr. Trump has repeatedly said is worth it for making sure Iran does not

obtain nuclear weapons. The national average for a gallon of diesel in the U.S. was \$6.37 on Friday, according to AAA, after hitting a record \$6.52 on September 22.

France holds the rotating presidency of the G7 group and made the announcement in a statement released after video-conference talks that Mr. Macron presided over. The International Energy Agency will coordinate the effort to combat soaring fuel prices.

"We will implement our commitments with a coordinated release through the IEA of 100 million barrels (MB) to begin immediately over 4 months, including a front-loaded substantial diesel release within the first 20 days by G7 members and partners," the statement said.

Scale of war recovery beyond state's capacity: Lebanon PM

Agence France-Presse
NABATIEH

Lebanese Prime Minister Nawaf Salam said on Friday that rebuilding regions destroyed in the latest Israel-Hezbollah war was beyond the state's capacity, calling for funding as he visited the heavily damaged south.

"I am aware of the magnitude of the crisis" including the destruction, displacement and loss of livelihoods, Mr. Salam said in Nabatieh, a major southern city hit hard by Israeli air strikes.

"But the scale of the needs exceeds the capacities of the Lebanese state and its ability to bear these burdens alone," Mr. Salam added. "We still need significant funding" for reconstruction, the Prime Minister said.

Lebanese militant group



Nawaf Salam

Hezbollah drew the country into the broader West Asia war in March by attacking Israel, which responded with massive air strikes and a ground invasion.

The fighting followed another conflict that erupted in 2023 that led to an all-out war the next year. Lebanon has put the overall death toll from these conflicts at more than 8,900.

Hundreds of thousands of people remain displaced, mainly from the

south, while Israel maintains troops in a self-declared "security zone" running around 10 km inside Lebanon along the border.

Last month, Mr. Salam said the estimated total cost of the two wars could exceed \$27 billion.

"I am here today to affirm the return to work of state institutions," he said during Friday's visit.

Violence has decreased since a ceasefire following a U.S.-Iran memorandum of understanding in June, while Lebanon and Israel concluded a U.S.-sponsored framework agreement later that month.

The Israel-Lebanon deal involves the disarmament of Hezbollah, a gradual withdrawal of Israeli forces from Lebanon's south and the deployment of the Lebanese army to the region, starting in test areas known as "pilot zones".

Fury in France



United voices: French masked high school students walk along a street as part of nationwide protests demanding the hiring of substitute teachers, increased resources and better learning conditions, in Toulouse, France, on Friday. REUTERS

Kim's sister in North Korea calls Seoul 'despicable'

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

Kim Yo-jong, the powerful sister of North Korea's leader, called Seoul "despicable" on Friday after it demanded an apology over a demilitarised zone blast.

Pyongyang has denied being behind a landmine blast that caused severe injuries to three soldiers last month inside the Demilitarised Zone (DMZ).

The South Korean military demanded an official apology this week, accusing Pyongyang of "a clear violation of the Armistice Agreement".

Kim Yo-jong, the sister of leader Kim Jong-un, said South Korea "even called for an apology" and added that it is "really despicable".

Netanyahu warns of 'heavy price' over flydubai incident

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu warned on Friday that Israel would impose a "very heavy price" on any power behind the flydubai incident, without offering evidence that any country was responsible.

"As time passes, the picture is becoming clearer: The attacker underwent Islamist radicalisation. He came to crash the plane with all passengers on

board," Mr. Netanyahu said.

"We are investigating whether he was sent, and whoever sent him will pay a very heavy price," Mr. Netanyahu said of the co-pilot assailant.

Mr. Netanyahu did not identify any country as a potential culprit but for years has been quick to point the finger at Iran.

U.S. President Donald Trump had said that he was "hearing" that Iran was involved and that it will "be hit very hard" if so.

Pakistan govt. in talks with Imran Khan's Opposition party as protest threat looms

Agence France-Presse
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan's government and the party of jailed former Prime Minister Imran Khan held talks on Friday over planned protests by his supporters that threaten to bring Islamabad to a standstill.

In anticipation of the protests calling for Mr. Khan's release, shipping containers requisitioned by authorities have stood for weeks along major highways and at key entry points to the Pakistani capital to stop arriving



Restricted access: Vehicles drive past shipping containers blocking a road towards the Red Zone area in Islamabad on Friday. AFP

demonstrators.

President Asif Ali Zardari's office said representatives from the government and Mr. Khan's Pakistan

Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) party were to meet on Friday to discuss the protests, planned for Sunday after being pushed back from

September 27.

State broadcaster PTV reported the meetings had concluded for the day and would resume on Saturday.

In a statement on Friday, PTI said it was prepared to go ahead with the protests, but party official Haleem Adil Sheikh said negotiations could move forward if the government showed flexibility on demands including the release of Mr. Khan's sisters, who were arrested last month.

"We are talking to the government today in a positive spirit," he said.

Taiwan receives two U.S. F-16Vs and awaits additional fighter jets

Associated Press
BANGKOK

Taiwan on Friday received the first two of 65 F-16V fighter jets ordered from the U.S., the island's Air Force said, following years of delays.

The two F-16V Block 70 jets landed at Chihhang Air Base in Taitung. There are 63 more to be delivered.

The self-ruled island, which is also claimed by Beijing as part of its territory, placed an order for the F-16Vs in 2019.

Taiwan largely purchases arms from the U.S., its largest unofficial ally, to boost its defences in the face of a military threat from China. China sends fighter jets and ships toward the island almost daily. Taiwan's Defence Minister said on Tuesday that the island remains in continuous discussions with the U.S. about their weapons sales.

The shipment is the first in a long list of backlogged U.S. orders worth almost \$30 billion.

How Hansi flicked the Raphinha switch

The Barcelona coach has unlocked a turbocharged version of the Brazilian attacker by shifting him from the wing to the centre-forward's position. Raphinha has exploded in his new role, rising to the top of the LaLiga scoring charts ahead of Lamine Yamal and Kylian Mbappe

Reuters
Associated Press

The move from the wing to the middle helped Ousmane Dembele assume his final form as an unstoppable force in the 2024-25 season and win the Ballon d'Or.

A similar shift from the flanks to the central spaces as a No. 9 appears to have unleashed a turbocharged version of Raphinha at Barcelona this season. The Brazil international has exploded in his new role, scoring 14 goals in eight matches, 12 in seven games in LaLiga, moving to the top of the scoring charts ahead of Lamine Yamal and Kylian Mbappe.

The striker hunt

Barcelona had spent the close season searching for a centre-forward after Robert Lewandowski left as a free agent for Major League Soccer, with Atletico Madrid's Julian Alvarez and Inter Milan captain Lautaro Martinez high on its list. The summer chase for Alvarez, which developed into a messy saga, ended in frustration for Barcelona, leaving the club short up front.

Barcelona eventually signed Gabriel Jesus as a rotational option for Hansi Flick's squad, but the surprise solution has come from within, with Raphinha moving from his hybrid attacking midfielder-right wing role into the centre-forward position.

"The idea was to bring in a forward with good movement and the ability to link up with others, and Julian [Alvarez] was one such player," said Barcelona sporting director Deco.

"We are happy because we discovered a new face of Raphinha. But more important is that he's happy too. It is different for him, because sometimes he's not in contact with the ball all the time like he used to. He needs to be prepared to attack behind the defenders. We expected that he could do well, but not at this level," Deco added. Indeed,

Yes, I had doubts. People judge you for goals, you're playing as a striker. And then there's the fact that you're playing in the spot where the one and only Robert Lewandowski played

RAPHINHA

the change in Raphinha's fortunes at Barcelona has been sudden and spectacular. He was convinced he was leaving two years ago after growing increasingly frustrated under Xavi Hernandez. But Flick's arrival as coach in 2024 proved a turning point: Raphinha, who has thrived under the German, was appointed captain at the start of the season after Ronald Araujo and Marc-Andre ter Stegen left the club and Frenkie de Jong was sidelined by a knee injury.

The coach's belief

In his first conversation with Raphinha, Flick had told the attacker that he believed in his talent. The start of this season has revealed the extent of the coach's belief. Flick had an idea that the 29-year-old's strengths would translate well from the wing to the centre. More to the point, he had the conviction to back his belief.

"In pre-season we did a few tests: the manager liked what he saw and told me a bit about his idea," Raphinha told the *Guardian*. "The adaptation came over the last two years, getting used to coming inside, closer to goal. But we tested [me

as] an actual No. 9 and it went well.

"There's the occasional detail that has to be explained, but I'm OK. Before Elche [on the opening day], he asked if I was comfortable there or wanted to go back to my position. I said it was fine, see how it goes, we can always change back."

There has been no reason to change. With 31

He gives us a lot, his dynamic is top but also without the ball he's good. He has that incredible hunger and intensity, the mentality and attitude we need

HANSI FLICK

goals in seven straight league wins – that's an average of 4.3 goals per match – Barcelona has the hottest attack in Europe, and Raphinha has led the charge in blistering fashion, scoring at will, including back-to-back hat-tricks.

The second of those came in Barcelona's biggest test of the season so far, at the Ramon Sanchez-Pizjuan in the final league fixture before the international break. With his side down a goal to Sevilla after 19 minutes, Raphinha responded in style. He scored a perfect hat-trick, applying three different finishes. All of them would have made the game's top No. 9s proud, for they showcased his skill, instinct, speed and sheer desire to score.

The first goal featured a diagonal in-to-out run onto Andreas Christensen's pass, a tricky feint that put his chasing marker on the ground, and a right-footed finish to the far corner. For the second, he burst out of the defender's blindside to head a Yamal floater expertly. He chipped the keeper off his stronger left foot for the third, this time after an out-to-in run.

"We know the quality of Raphinha," Flick said after the game. "He gives us a lot, his dynamic is top but also without the ball he's good. He has that incredible hunger and intensity, the mentality and attitude we need. After these eight games, I think he's very happy to play as a No. 9."

Interestingly, for someone who has taken to the job like a duck to water, Raphinha wasn't sure at the beginning. "Yes, I had doubts," Raphinha told *Rac+I* when asked about the transition. "Because people judge you for goals, at the end of the day, you're playing as a striker. And then there's the fact that you're playing in the spot where the one and only Robert Lewandowski played. So if you don't score goals, people judge you for that, they demand that from you."

The former Leeds United forward, who joined Barcelona in 2022, has now scored 89 goals in 185 appearances for the Blaugrana, which places him among the top 30 scorers in the club's history. He needs just five more goals to equal the legendary Ronaldinho.

Tellingly, 69 of Raphinha's Barcelona goals have come under Flick, who has led the Catalans to LaLiga titles in each of his two seasons.

"I've always said it and I will always say it, he's the manager that changed both my mentality within the club and also what I thought about myself," Raphinha told *DAZN*. "I'm very grateful for him, and I will demonstrate it whenever I can."

What lies ahead

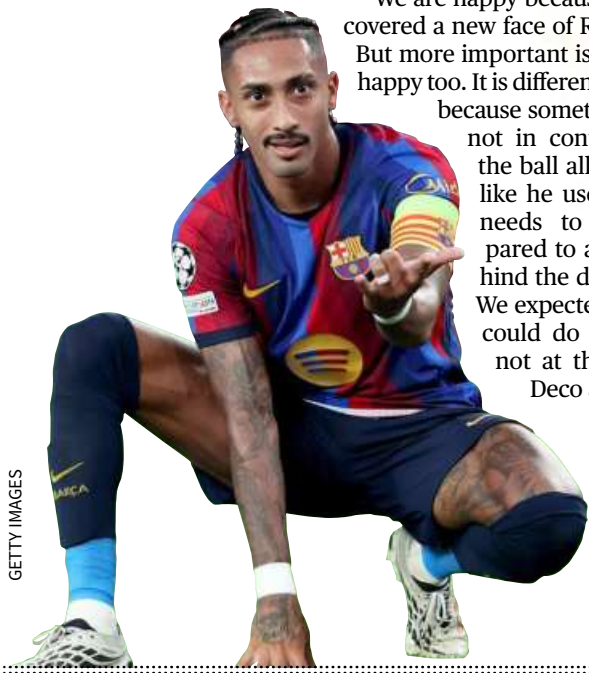
It's no surprise that the player wants to extend his stay at the club.

"Given the way I've started the season, I think I can keep going for a few more years. I'm in spectacular physical shape so [retirement] is some way off. I would be very happy to extend my contract and, hopefully, finish my career here without having to go elsewhere," Raphinha told *RACI* radio.

"It's always important to keep in mind that you need to improve in some areas. I'll never say I'm at my peak, because I always try to improve as much as I can. There's surely something more I can contribute to the team than what I'm currently giving."

It will be interesting to see just how Raphinha's time at No. 9 plays out. Will he have a season for the ages like Dembele did and maybe even enjoy a late-career swing as an elite striker? Or will it be no more than a short-term fix, even if it is successful?

All we know for sure is that Raphinha, like he has through his career, will give it everything.



GETTY IMAGES

STACKING UP

ATP Men's Top 15				
#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	11,000	16
2	Alexander Zverev	29	9,630	19
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	5,060	16
4	Ben Shelton	23	4,680	22
5	Felix Auger-Aliassime	26	3,890	22
6	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,710	23
7	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,680	25
8	Frances Tiafoe	28	3,380	21
9	Arthur Fils	22	3,150	18
10	Alex de Minaur	27	3,150	23
11	Novak Djokovic	39	2,980	15
12	Taylor Fritz	28	2,880	21
13	Rafael Nadal	20	2,659	21
14	Jakub Mensik	21	2,405	20
15	Learner Tien	20	2,395	20



Top Indians



Sumit Nagal
Rank 249 ▼ 1 spot



Dhakshinewar Suresh
Rank 364 ▼ 5 spots

WTA Women's Top 15				
#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Elena Rybakina	27	9,901	21
2	Aryna Sabalenka	28	7,810	20
3	Jessica Pegula	32	7,265	19
4	Coco Gauff	22	7,244	19
5	Mirra Andreeva	19	5,841	21
6	Linda Noskova	21	5,328	20
7	Elina Svitolina	32	4,809	17
8	Karolina Muchova	30	4,683	20
9	Iga Swiatek	25	4,119	19
10	Marta Kostyuk	24	4,040	18
11	Amanda Anisimova	25	3,363	15
12	Belinda Bencic	29	2,925	19
13	Iva Jovic	18	2,841	23
14	Diana Shnaider	22	2,588	23
15	Victoria Mboko	20	2,521	19

Top Indians



Sahaja Yamalapalli
Rank 354 ▼ 5 spots



Vaishnavi Adkar
Rank 374 ▼ 13 spots

F1 Drivers' standings				
#	Driver	Team	Points	Wins
1	A.K. Antonelli	Mercedes	302	8
2	G. Russell	Mercedes	236	3
3	L. Hamilton	Ferrari	199	1
4	L. Norris	McLaren	186	2
5	C. Leclerc	Ferrari	179	1
6	M. Verstappen	Red Bull	163	0
7	O. Piastri	McLaren	120	0
8	I. Hadjar	Red Bull	86	0
9	L. Lawson	RB	59	0
10	P. Gasly	Alpine	41	0
11	A. Lindblad	RB	37	0
12	F. Colapinto	Alpine	27	0
13	O. Bearman	Haas	20	0
14	G. Bortoleto	Audi	10	0
15	N. Hulkenberg	Audi	7	0
16	E. Ocon	Haas	7	0
17	C. Sainz	Williams	7	0
18	A. Albon	Williams	5	0
19	F. Alonso	Aston Martin	3	0
20	Y. Tsunoda	RB	1	0
21	V. Bottas	Cadillac	0	0
22	S. Perez	Cadillac	0	0
23	L. Stroll	Aston Martin	0	0



A.K. Antonelli



G. Russell

F1 Constructors' standings			
Pos	Team	Points	Wins
1	Mercedes	538	11
2	Ferrari	378	2
3	McLaren	306	2
4	Red Bull	263	0
5	RB	83	0
6	Alpine	68	0
7	Haas	27	0
8	Audi	17	0
9	Williams	12	0
10	Aston Martin	3	0
11	Cadillac	0	0

Badminton Men's ranking			
#	Player	Points	Events
1	Kunlavut Vitidsarn	86,915	16
2	Christo Popov	86,632	19
3	Jonatan Christie	84,431	16
4	Shi Yu Qi	84,075	13
5	Chou Tien Chen	83,680	25
6	Anders Antonsen	83,655	16
7	Kodai Naraoka	77,540	18
8	Alex Lanier	76,985	15
9	Victor Lai	76,465	17
10	Alwi Farhan	70,099	16
11	Lin Chun-Yi	64,924	17
12	Li Shi Feng	64,533	15
13	Loh Kean Yew	63,140	18
14	Lakshya Sen	62,813	20
15	Toma Junior Popov	62,697	19



Top Indians



Lakshya Sen
Rank 14



Ayush Shetty
Rank 20

Badminton Women's ranking			
#	Player	Points	Events
1	An Se Young	1,21,287	14
2	Wang Zhi Yi	1,03,989	15
3	Akane Yamaguchi	1,02,576	17
4	Chen Yu Fei	86,651	14
5	Ratchanok Intanon	74,606	19
6	Putri Kusuma Wardani	71,603	16
7	Tomoka Miyazaki	71,456	20
8	Han Yue	69,008	12
9	Pornpawee Chochuwong	66,927	14
10	Nozomi Okuhara	64,160	17
11	P.V. Sindhu	64,151	12
12	Kim Ga Eun	59,041	15
13	Line Christophersen	57,940	21
14	Michelle Li	55,327	20
15	Mia Blichfeldt	54,483	11

Top Indians



P.V. Sindhu
Rank 11



Unnati Hooda
Rank 24

Test Batting			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	861	898
2	Steve Smith	840	947
3	Joe Root	816	932
4	Travis Head	811	884
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Kamindu Mendis	706	784

Test Bowling			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	872	872
2	Matt Henry	861	870
3	Ollie Robinson	856	856
4	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
5	Pat Cummins	841	914
6	Marco Jansen	825	825
7	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
8	Scott Boland	804	820
9	Josh Hazlewood	783	864
10	Noman Ali	777	853

ODI Batting			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	816	841
2	Virat Kohli	796	908
3	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
4	Rohit Sharma	753	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Kusal Mendis	674	675
8	Shai Hope	673	782
9	Joe Root	660	810
10	Harry Tector	653	730

ODI Bowling			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	714	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	675	675
3	Keshav Maharaj	667	737
4	Mitchell Santner	644	656
5	Kuldeep Yadav	623	757
6	Maheesh Theekshana	622	680
7	Jofra Archer	617	682
8	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	602	722
10	Josh Hazlewood	591	725

T20I Batting			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	892	910
2	Abhishek Sharma	887	931
3	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
4	Harry Brook	793	793
5	Jos Buttler	789	794
6	Dewald Brevis	789	806
7	Phil Salt	775	881
8	Pathum Nissanka	757	796
9	Tilak Varma	719	845
10	Mitchell Marsh	706	706

T20I Bowling			
#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Abrar Ahmed	736	757
2	Rashid Khan	720	828
3	Adam Zampa	700	746
4	Adil Rashid	695	747
5	Nathan Ellis	675	678
6	Jamie Overton	674	674
7	Varun Chakaravarthy	665	818
8	Mohammad Nawaz	658	672
9	Wanindu Hasaranga	656	809
10	Liam Dawson	648	652

